Hermeneutics and Exegesis for Laypeople

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Preface

Welcome to *Hermeneutics and Exegesis for Laypeople*. This book was about four years in the making. I was co-leading a bible study in Los Angeles when we came to an important realization. If you wanted to teach people how to study their Bibles more deeply, there was very little intermediate material available. You had beginner studies covering basic concepts like the inductive method, and then you had seminary textbooks. How could we bridge the gap?

We decided to hold a Saturday morning seminar. It was four hours long: two one-and-a-half-hour sessions with a lunch hour in between. We hosted about thirty-five people at our house. A good friend cooked an incredible barbeque lunch for everyone. It was wonderful. The content was well-received and proved helpful for everyone.

Each successive year, I somehow found an opportunity to teach this seminar in a different context. And each time, I incrementally refined the content. I taught it to eighty deacons and small group leaders one Saturday morning at church. While my wife and I lived in Africa, I taught it to two young church members over several months (usually after dinner, by candlelight, during power outages). I led seminars over Zoom during the COVID-19 pandemic for my local church and a friend's church. The content morphed and changed over time, always positively. Feedback from participants, friends, and elders strengthened what was already there and added new perspectives that were missing.

At this point, the course was essentially a PowerPoint presentation accompanied by lectures. I began to ponder how to expand this content and make it more useful. I had the idea to convert it into a book. Ideally, this book would be short. It would be helpful for both individuals and small groups. And it could serve as a springboard for fresh

iterations of this content: discussion guides, small group curriculum, and new focus areas, including *Application and Homiletics for Laypeople*.

That's the story of this book. This book is essentially an adaptation of a seminar: slides that have become sections, bullet points that have become paragraphs, and so on. I hope you find it helpful. Whatever version of this book you're reading now, there will probably be another one after it. Isaiah 40:8 says, *"The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God stands forever."* The trends and terminologies of hermeneutics and exegesis are like the grass and flowers in this verse: they wither, fade, and regrow each season. These concepts flourish in an environment of constant iteration.

In the same way, I encourage you to develop your own habit of relentless improvement; take this content and incrementally refine it on your own. But keep this truth in front of you: "the word of our God stands forever." God's Word never changes.

1. Introduction

This book is an introduction to intermediate Bible study concepts.

If you're a brand new believer, unfamiliar with the Bible or inductive study, some of these concepts may go over your head. And if you're an experienced exegete, this book will probably retread old ground. However (with that disclaimer aside), I've seen new believers and seminarians alike benefit from this material. Sometimes, the best way to learn something new is to get just slightly in over your head. And sometimes, the best way to stay sharp is to go back to the basics.

I hope this book encourages and serves you wherever you are. My goal is to foster confidence, not primarily in ourselves but in God's Word. When you study your Bible, I want you to feel confident that it is clear. Through informed and prayerful study, you can understand what God has revealed and explain it to edify yourself and others.

Why This Matters

Most people would agree that hermeneutics and exegesis matter for pastors, professors, and other "professional" Christians. But why do ordinary Christians need to go that deep? Why does it matter for you and me? I want to propose three reasons why.

Because it was revealed to you!

Deuteronomy 29:29 says this, *"The secret things belong to the LORD our God, but the things revealed belong to us and to our sons forever, that we may observe all the words of this law."* In other words, some things have not been revealed to us, things we will never know this side of heaven. But, on the other hand, there is much that has been revealed to us.

The Bible is full of information about God, His plan, His desires, His people, and the world He created. And Deuteronomy 29:29 says that these things were revealed to us "that we may observe" them – so that we would understand and obey. Hermeneutics and exegesis matter to ordinary Christians because Scripture has been revealed to us, and we are responsible for understanding and obeying it.

Because wolves don't go after the shepherds!

In Matthew 7:15, Jesus says, *"Beware of false prophets, who come to you in sheep's clothing, but inwardly are ravenous wolves."* He's warning us about people who pretend to be fellow Christians to serve their own malicious interests. And He calls them "false prophets." They're preachers and pastors and professors – public men claiming to speak for God. But Jesus calls them "ravenous wolves," that is, predators.

Later on, in Acts 20:29-30, Paul uses similar language with the elders at Ephesus. *"I know that after my departure savage wolves will come in among you, not sparing the flock; and from among your own selves men will arise, speaking perverse things, to draw away the disciples after them."* Note that Paul is speaking to the leaders of the church. He's saying that these spiritual predators will arise "from among your own selves," that is, not from among the congregants but from among the elders.

It's very rare to find a false teacher who is content to remain an ordinary Christian. False teachers are usually in it for money or power, and you can't get those things by being a nobody. They crave influence; they need followers. Like wolves who don't hunt the shepherds but rather the sheep, these false teachers don't usually go after our pastors. They go after us. Hermeneutics and exegesis matter to ordinary Christians because ordinary Christians are the primary target of our enemy's deceit.

Because you're in the ministry!

I love what Ephesians 4:11-12 says about ministry. *"And [God] gave some as apostles, and some as prophets, and some as evangelists, and some as pastors and teachers, for the equipping of the saints for the work of ministry."* It's not the apostles, prophets, evangelists, and pastor-teachers who are "in the ministry" (as we like to say). It's the saints who are "in the ministry." The work of the leaders is to equip the saints for their ministry. Think about that.

We aren't in the pew to support our pastor in his ministry; our pastor is in the pulpit to support us in our ministry! God wants to use us to encourage, admonish, instruct, and inform the people around us. It's our job to evangelize the lost and disciple the saved. And it's our pastors' job to set us up for success. Hermeneutics and exegesis matter to ordinary Christians because we're in the ministry.

Defining Terms

Before we dive in, there are some essential terms I'd like to define. While it's unnecessary to memorize these, I will continue to refer to them throughout this book. It might be helpful to read these definitions a few times, carefully, before moving on.

> **Interpretation** – *A judgment as to the meaning of a text.*
>
> **Hermeneutics** – *The principles used to determine an interpretation of a text.*
>
> **Exegesis** – *The process used to determine an interpretation of a text.*
>
> **Authorial Intent** – *The original meaning intended by the author of a text.*

As you've probably noticed, this book derives its title from these two middle terms: hermeneutics and exegesis. Some people use these terms almost interchangeably, but I

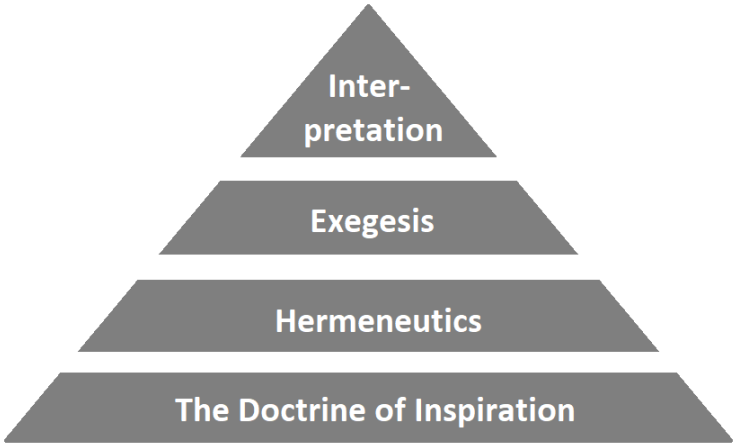
want to commend a more precise usage because they do mean slightly different things. Where hermeneutics refers to principles, exegesis refers to a process. It's a bit like doing science.

On the one hand, you have the scientific method: a set of principles that govern the practice of scientific discovery. But on the other hand, you have the actual process of "doing science." You could be a field researcher fetching soil samples in a remote jungle, a lab technician examining those samples under a microscope, or a developer building a virtual dashboard to analyze millions of those samples statistically. All these different jobs and procedures are ultimately governed by the same investigative principles that drive all scientific pursuits.

Hermeneutics and exegesis are similar. A set of hermeneutical principles ultimately govern all the various exegetical processes involved in interpreting a passage of Scripture. These principles are often unconscious, but everyone has a hermeneutic, whether they know it or not. We must become more self-aware. How are we reading the Bible? What underlying presuppositions do we bring to the table? And are those principles coherent and consistent?

The Pyramid of Interpretation

There's an illustration I like to use to demonstrate the importance of foundations when interpreting the Bible. I call it "The Pyramid of Interpretation." This illustration will also function as our outline for the remainder of this book, and I'll return to it often.



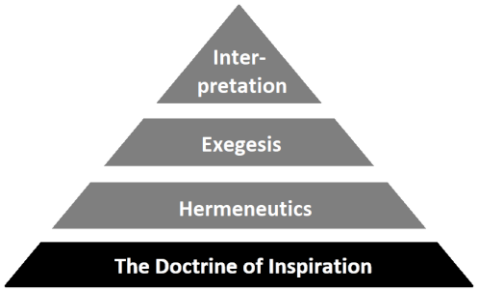
Why a pyramid?

Because there's only one way to build a pyramid: from the ground up. You can't reach the finest point without first building upon a much broader foundation. And the study of God's Word works the same way. Increasingly specific sets of principles drive our practices.

As we work our way up the pyramid, we're going to brave a little complexity in order to arrive at a more educated kind of simplicity. I'll first introduce you to some complex topics to challenge you to think more intentionally about how you study the Bible. Then I'll give you some simple, practical tools to use in your own Bible study.

Remember our definitions. **Interpretation** (*a judgment about the meaning of a text*) rests upon exegesis. **Exegesis** (*the process used to determine an interpretation*) rests upon hermeneutics. And **Hermeneutics** (*the principles used to determine an interpretation*) rests upon something called "The Doctrine of Inspiration." So that's where we'll start.

2. The Doctrine of Inspiration



At each level of our pyramid, I've chosen a passage of Scripture that embodies, exemplifies, or explains that concept well. Let's begin with 2 Timothy 3:16-17.

> *"All Scripture is inspired by God and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in righteousness; so that the man of God may be adequate, equipped for every good work."*

In the original Greek text, the phrase "inspired by God" is a single word: *theopneustos*. It means "breathed out by God." By using this word, Paul is saying that God is the source of all Scripture; that is, it has proceeded directly from God. This truth distinguishes Scripture from other writings. We have many outstanding Christian books available to us, but only the Bible was breathed out by God.

Paul also says that Scripture is "profitable" precisely because it is God-breathed. Due to its uniquely divine origin, Scripture is helpful in a way that no other writings are. That doesn't mean that we should reject other sources of truth as useless, but we should recognize that the Bible is uniquely useful to Christians.

This idea (that Scripture is God-breathed) is what we mean by the term "inspiration." Now, there are multiple ways to think about inspiration. We'll discuss some competing views in a moment. But first, I want to look at the most logical, biblical perspective and the one that Christians have affirmed throughout the ages.

> **Verbal Plenary Inspiration** – *The precise wording of Scripture has been breathed out by God, and therefore bears God's authority.*

It's a complicated term for a relatively simple concept.

By **"verbal,"** we mean that God delivered His revelation in the form of words, gathered into phrases that convey meaning. Now, this doesn't mean that God never communicates non-verbally. In Romans 1:20, Paul says that *"since the creation of the world His invisible attributes, His eternal power and divine nature, have been clearly seen, being understood through what has been made."*

But the Bible is different. Hebrews 1:1-2 says, *"God, after He spoke long ago to the fathers in the prophets in many portions and in many ways, in these last days has spoken to us in His Son."* As New Testament believers, we have received the complete revelation of God in verbal form. That's why we refer to it as "the Word of God."

By **"plenary,"** we mean that it possesses unqualified and absolute authority. If you've ever been to a large Christian conference, the event schedule may have distinguished between "breakout" sessions and "plenary" sessions. A plenary session is the main event, a large gathering where everyone sits under the preaching of the Word together. And in the context of inspiration, that term conveys the universal authority of God's Word.

Verbal Plenary Inspiration, then, is the view that God sovereignly directed the authors of Scripture to communicate His exact message. Each word, sentence, paragraph, book,

corpus, testament, and indeed the whole canon is composed precisely according to God's design. Nothing is missing; nothing is out of place.

Furthermore, because this message is God-breathed, it possesses His authority. If you subscribe to this view, you essentially read these ancient documents as the very words of God Himself. From this understanding, we derive an important principle about the doctrine of inspiration:

Scripture is the Word of God, and the words of God.

What do I mean by this? People will often say something like, "While I agree that the Bible is God's Word, I don't believe that every single part of the Bible is the actual words of God." They like the big ideas of the Bible, but they're not confident that every story is factual or every command is binding.

But with a Verbal Plenary view of inspiration, we would reject this kind of statement. We believe that Scripture is not only the Word of God (an accurate representation of His overall message); it's also the words of God (stories, statements, and commands that have come directly from God). Psalm 119:60 says, *"The sum of Your word is truth, and every one of Your righteous ordinances is everlasting."* It's not either-or, it's both-and!

In another passage, David provides a fascinating description of how Verbal Plenary Inspiration worked. He says in 2 Samuel 23:2, *"The Spirit of the Lord spoke by me, and His word was on my tongue."* He is describing a kind of dual authorship. When we read a Davidic psalm, was David the author? Yes. Was God the author? Also yes. The Holy Spirit's message came to us through the mouth of David. God didn't override David's free will. Through David's own skill, language, life experience, and artistic impulse, God sovereignly produced the exact message He desired to impart to His people. That's how Verbal Plenary Inspiration works.

Competing Views

There are several competing theories of inspiration, other beliefs about how God put meaning into the biblical text. As we examine them, it's important to remember our definition of **Authorial Intent** (*the original meaning intended by the author of a text*). We'll notice how each of these views thinks about authorial intent.

> **Dictation** – *God bypassed the intentions and circumstances of the human authors, "dictating" the entire content of the Bible***.**

Imagine you need to respond to a text message while driving. You might hand your phone to a passenger and tell them precisely what to write. Or you might use voice recognition to transcribe your message automatically. To the person on the receiving end, it doesn't necessarily matter what method you've used, as long as your message was transcribed accurately. This is very similar to the Dictation Theory of inspiration.

There's a nugget of truth here; God did indeed dictate some parts of the Bible. For example, the Sinaitic Law is essentially Moses' record of what God told him to write. And in Revelation 1-3, we have John's transcript of Christ's message to several first-century churches. However, Dictation Theory proposes that God dictated the entire Bible in this way. In this view, authorial intent is unimportant. The intentions and circumstances of the human author have little to do with interpreting their writings because the human authors were simply stenographers.

> **Partial/Conceptual** – *God impressed concepts into the minds of the human authors, and they wrote about them in detailed but potentially flawed ways.*

Have you ever played a game of telephone? You whisper something to the person on your right, and they repeat it to the person on their right until the phrase goes around the entire table. By the time it makes its way back into your left ear, it may be a

completely different concept than you originally intended. Each individual's understanding corrupts and contorts the original phrase. That's similar to how the Partial/Conceptual view of inspiration works.

In this view, passages that speak against homosexuality may be considered a product of their time. You could reduce the Creation account to a simple rehash of Ancient Near-Eastern mythology. These passages may not represent God's opinion as much as the human author's culture. In this view, authorial intent is still fundamentally important. But it's important because it's obscuring the truth. The intentions and circumstances of the human authors interfere with the message that God's trying to convey.

> **Natural** – *There is no divinity in the inspiration of the Bible. The intentions and circumstances of the human authors are all there is, and therefore, they have no real authority.*

In this view, there is no supernatural distinction between the Bible and any other historical document. The Scriptures are simply the writings of wise men. They are no more inherently authoritative or profitable than the writings of Oprah or the Bhagavad Ghita. A proponent of the Natural view might say, "The authors of the Bible were extraordinarily gifted writers, poets, and perhaps even gifted fortune-tellers, but not vessels of divine truth."

In this case, there is only authorial intent. There is no dual authorship, no "God-breathed" nature to the Scriptures. There is nothing more than the intentions and circumstances of the human authors. And therefore, there is no absolute authority behind the Scriptures. You can accept or reject the truth claims of the Bible as you would the opinions of any human writer.

Summary

None of these competing views are sufficient to explain the Inspiration of Scripture. Verbal Plenary Inspiration is the most logical, biblical view available to us. As we continue to the next level of our pyramid, we'll continue to flesh out the implications of this view for the study of God's Word.

Below, I've provided a few helpful aids on this topic of inspiration. First, I've included a short (not exhaustive!) list of Scripture references for additional study. Second, you'll find some discussion questions to help you think through what you've learned. And lastly, I've listed two books that will help you explore this topic in more depth (the first is an easier read, the second more difficult). For the remainder of this book, each chapter will conclude with similar resources.

Scripture References

- 2 Samuel 23:2
- Matthew 5:18
- Mark 12:36
- Luke 1:70
- Acts 1:16
- Acts 28:25
- Romans 3:2
- Galatians 3:8
- Hebrews 1:1

Discussion Questions

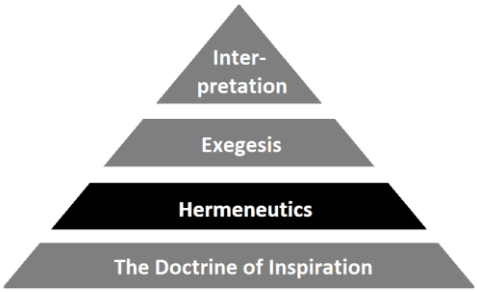
1. How might your own Bible study change if you held to a different view of inspiration?
2. How does knowing that God's revelation is "verbal" impact how you study the Bible?

3. How does knowing that God's revelation is "plenary" impact how you study the Bible?

Recommended Reading

- *Can I Trust the Bible?* by R.C. Sproul
- *The Inspiration and Authority of the Bible* by B.B. Warfield

3. Hermeneutics



We've already looked at the foundation of our pyramid. Now we're going to move up a level. And as we do, it's important to remember our definition of **Hermeneutics**: *The principles used to determine an interpretation of a text.*

Throughout the gospels, we find several passages in which Jesus asks the religious leaders a particularly piercing question: "Have you not read?" (Matthew 12:3, 5, 19:4, 21:16, 42, 23:31, Mark 2:25, 12:10, 26, Luke 6:3) Now, Jesus didn't mean they had never read the Scriptures; it was a rhetorical question. As the premier experts in Mosaic Law, they had read the Scriptures more than anyone. Instead, Jesus was implying that they had misread the Scriptures. Their hermeneutic was so misinformed that it was almost as if they had never read the Scriptures at all.

You see, hermeneutics is all about the presuppositions we bring to the text. Why do we read the Bible the way we do? As we consider this topic, we mustn't miss the brilliance of 2 Peter 1:19-21.

> *"So we have the prophetic word made more sure, to which you do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the*

> *morning star arises in your hearts. But know this first of all, that no prophecy of Scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation, for no prophecy was ever made by an act of human will, but men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God."*

In verse 19, Peter says, **"We have the prophetic word made more sure."** More sure than what? If we read the previous sentence, we find a reference to the Mount of Transfiguration. *"For when [Jesus] received honor and glory from God the Father, such an utterance was made to Him by the Majestic Glory, 'This is my beloved Son with whom I am well-pleased' – and we ourselves heard this utterance made from heaven when we were with Him on the holy mountain."* (For the full story, read Matthew 17:1-9.) Peter's encounter on the Mount of Transfiguration wasn't a vision or a dream; it was a genuine experience of the glory of God. But one verse later, he says that Scripture is "made more sure." In other words, the God-breathed writings of the Bible are a more trustworthy source of truth than even personal experience. If we hold to verbal plenary inspiration, this should come as no surprise. If we truly possess the written revelation of the One who "created the heavens and the earth" (Genesis 1:1) and "upholds all things by the word of His power" (Hebrews 1:3), then it surely exceeds whatever limited wisdom or experience we possess.

Notice the imagery in what Peter says next: **"To which you do well to pay attention as to a lamp shining in a dark place, until the day dawns and the morning star arises in your hearts."** The world has been a dark place ever since sin entered it. People keep secrets from one another. Our human faculties – perception, reasoning, conceptualization – have been corrupted due to the Fall. It's difficult to determine the truth. There will come a day when God will remove those limitations and withhold no cosmic mystery from us. 1 Corinthians 13:12 puts it eloquently, *"For now we see in a mirror dimly, but then face to face; now I know in part, but then I will know fully just as I also have been fully known."*

But until that day, we must use Scripture as "a lamp shining in a dark place." Like a flashlight on a starless night, Scripture is a tool for understanding the world around us. That's what Peter's getting at in this verse. Because the Word of God is more trustworthy than personal experience, we must strive to examine everything in its light. We must "take every thought captive to the obedience of Christ" (2 Corinthians 10:5), "leaning not on our own understanding" (Proverbs 3:5), but acknowledging the wisdom of God in the Scriptures as our primary source of truth.

That's a compelling reality, isn't it? I hope we're eager to comply! But even as we rush to put this into practice, Peter pumps the brakes. His next phrase comes abruptly: **"But know this first of all."** In other words, before you take these principles and run with them, there's something you must know.

"No prophecy of Scripture is a matter of one's own interpretation." When Peter uses the term "prophecy" here, he's not referring to passages about the future or a genre of Old Testament literature. He's referring to the concept of inspired proclamation. In this sense, any statement that proceeds directly from God is a "prophecy." Since "all Scripture is inspired by God" (2 Timothy 3:16), every word, phrase, sentence, paragraph, and book of the Bible is "prophecy" in the way Peter is using the term here. So what's he getting at?

He's saying that the meaning of a biblical text is not a matter of subjective interpretation. As human readers, we don't get to determine the meaning of the Scriptures; we simply discover the meaning of the Scriptures. Think about that. One passage can't mean two different things based on who's reading it or how they understand it.

Well, why not? Peter goes on to give us the reason. **"For no prophecy was ever made by an act of human will."** In saying this, Peter rejects the Natural Theory of Inspiration

and affirms that Scripture is God-breathed. Scripture didn't originate from men alone, and it didn't acquire meaning apart from God. Therefore, we're not free to reinterpret it. We are bound to understand it the way God meant it to be understood. Notice how Peter leans into Verbal Plenary Inspiration in his final phrase.

"But men moved by the Holy Spirit spoke from God." We've already discussed passages like 2 Timothy 3:16-17 and 2 Samuel 23:2. And as we can see, Peter's clearly on the same page as Paul and David. God sovereignly used the skills, languages, and life experiences of human authors to produce the exact message He desired to communicate to His people. In describing this beautiful dual authorship, Peter affirms that the precise wording of Scripture is God-breathed and bears God's authority.

This passage is brilliant, and it demonstrates something essential. For Peter, the Doctrine of Inspiration was foundational for hermeneutics. Do you see that? If we hold to anything other than Verbal Plenary Inspiration, we can ultimately reinterpret any passage to mean anything we want. But if we agree with what the Bible says about itself, affirming its dual authorship, we can derive objective meaning from the Scriptures.

In 2 Peter 1:19-21, Peter advocates a straightforward, literal, but Spirit-empowered reading of the Scriptures. And from this text, we can derive an important hermeneutical principle.

How we get meaning out of the text depends on how God put meaning into the text!

As we interpret Scripture, we're not changing the meaning of Scripture. God determined the meaning of Scripture when He inspired it. And we must extract that meaning in alignment with the circumstances and intentions of the human authors that God used to communicate His message.

This principle also highlights the role of prayer in accurate Bible interpretation. God put meaning into the text through the Holy Spirit. Therefore, our efforts to extract meaning from the text must also involve the Holy Spirit. Just as the Spirit "moved" the authors, He must illuminate the readers. We must keep this in mind as we study the Bible. I often begin my daily reading with a short prayer from Psalm 119:18, asking the Spirit to guide my interpretation. *"Open my eyes, that I may behold wonderful things from Your law."*

Now, just as there are multiple theories of inspiration, there are also multiple approaches to hermeneutics. We'll look at some imbalanced, insufficient views in a moment. But first, I'll recommend what I believe is the most consistent, biblical way of reading the Scriptures. This approach is called the "literal historical grammatical" hermeneutic. Let's explore this concept.

> **Literal Historical Grammatical Hermeneutic** – *A commonsense reading, taking into account the historical setting and linguistic choices of the author to determine his originally intended meaning.*

By **"literal,"** we mean *rooted in normal human methods of communication*. We don't interpret Scripture as an ethereal, symbolic, or mystical mode of communication. Instead, we interpret it as literature. The Bible communicates God's truth in regular, understandable terms; no secret meanings hide beneath the surface.

Now, a word of clarification: by "literal," I do not mean "hyper-literal." You may be familiar with a series of children's books called *Amelia Bedelia*, in which the titular nanny constantly misinterprets figurative language. When her employer tells her to "draw the drapes," she gets out a pen and paper; or when she is asked to "dust the furniture," she coats the couch in baby powder. Obviously, these are exaggerated scenarios meant to teach children the importance of context when interpreting normal human methods of communication. But the same rules apply to the Bible.

For example, Solomon used figurative language to describe the sun in Ecclesiastes 1:5. *"The sun rises and the sun sets; and hastening to its place it rises there again."* But in the 1500s, when Copernicus first proposed the heliocentric model of the solar system, religious opponents used this verse against him. They insisted that God's Word contradicted his model because, at face value, this verse describes the sun moving around the earth. However, we understand that Solomon is simply using normal human methods of communication. In reality, the earth revolves around the sun. But even knowing this, we still speak of the "sunrise" and "sunset." We aren't making a scientific statement; we're just using language grounded in our experience. And we must assume the same of Solomon. Like any of us, the biblical authors used figurative language that we should not interpret hyper-literally.

By **"historical,"** we mean *rooted in the historical context of the time it was written*. We understand that even though God's Word is timeless, He inspired it through the life experiences of human authors who lived in various historical eras. Therefore, to understand the meaning of the Scriptures, we must understand the people, places, events, and worldviews they reference.

When you're reading a book from a different historical era, themes and references often go unnoticed until you learn a bit more about its original context. Imagine reading *Huckleberry Finn* with no awareness of American slavery. You might enjoy the swashbuckling adventure, but you would miss a great deal of what Mark Twain was trying to say. And it's the same way with the Bible; its meaning is rooted in a historical context.

And by **"grammatical,"** we mean *rooted in the linguistic context of the languages in which it was written.* God did not inspire the Scriptures in English. The human authors wrote in ancient Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek. Even though God's Word transcends ethnic and

linguistic barriers, He inspired it through human authors who wrote in various ancient languages.

Have you ever watched a foreign film? Some things get lost in translation. Even with subtitles or English dubs, you miss some of the original screenplay's nuances. It's complicated to translate humor, rhyme, wordplay, or slang from one language into another, even more so with ancient languages. And yet, the Bible is chock-full of humor, rhyme, wordplay, and slang in ancient Hebrew, Aramaic, and Greek. In the 21st Century, we're blessed with plenty of reliable, academically rigorous translations of the Bible – but no translation will capture every nuance. We must acknowledge that the truth of the Scriptures is rooted in various linguistic contexts.

Now, we're getting into territory that requires frequent clarification, and here's another one. Although I am commending the "literal historical grammatical" hermeneutic, I am not saying that literature, history, and grammar are the only important considerations in understanding the Bible. For example, we must also understand a text's *canonical and theological significance*. Biblical theology ought to inform our reading of any Scripture. However, this quickly becomes a complicated subject, and one we will touch on later. For now, let's examine some imbalanced, insufficient approaches to hermeneutics.

Imbalanced Views

At one time, I called this section "Competing Views," but a friend encouraged me to rename it. There are two reasons for this. First of all, there are far more competing views than can be captured in this chapter, and an effort to catalog all of them would be a book unto itself. Instead, what you'll find here are three streamlined categories representing a wide swath of objections to the literal historical grammatical hermeneutic. Secondly, these views are not truly "competing." In fact, each revolves

around an important truth that is simply over-emphasized. That is to say: *none of these views are **never** the right way to read Scripture, and none of these views are **always** the right way to read Scripture.* Let's look at them one by one.

> **Moral/Allegorical Hermeneutic** – *An application-driven reading, prioritizing the personal relevance of the text over the actual meaning of the text.*

In this view, what the text means to me is more important than what the text meant to the original authors. If we read the story of David and Goliath in this way, we might take its meaning to be: "God wants me to be courageous and face my giants in His strength!" Now, that's not an invalid thought. But the original author (presumably Samuel) didn't record that story to make that point. In our rush to apply this text to ourselves, we may have missed its actual significance.

For another example, take John 19:30. *"Therefore when Jesus had received the sour wine, He said, 'It is finished!' And He bowed His head and gave up His spirit."* If our hermeneutic prioritized the personal relevance of this text, we might arrive at something like this: "Christ's death teaches us the meaning of sacrificial love for one another." Now, that is indeed a biblical truth. And Paul makes that point in Philippians 2:5 (*"Have this attitude in yourselves which was also in Christ Jesus"*). But that's not John's purpose in this particular narrative. In this case, John is highlighting the completed nature of Christ's work on the cross.

As I mentioned, there's an important truth in this view that's simply over-emphasized. There are indeed morals, fables, and allegories in Scripture. For example, Jesus' parables were often allegorical. Many Old Testament prophecies used metaphor and symbolic imagery. And we also find stories and statements that teach moral lessons. The Proverbs are an obvious example of this. When Nathan confronted David about his sin with Bathsheba, he told an allegorical story. In other words, it didn't actually happen; it

was a carefully constructed illustration designed to impart a moral lesson. However, this is not how we are to interpret all of Scripture.

> **Anagogical Hermeneutic** – *A mystical or codical reading, often attempting to identify secret patterns of words, numbers, or locations in order to unpack a more significant meaning.*

In this view, word choice (diction) is more significant than word order (context.) I sometimes refer to this as the "National Treasure" approach to the Scriptures. If you've seen that movie, you know what I'm talking about. Historical documents like the Declaration of Independence are full of riddles and codes, unbeknownst to the average reader. But if you can follow the clues and solve the puzzle, you will discover long-hidden wealth and riches.

Many of the Early Church Fathers had a similar view of Scripture. Today, this anagogical hermeneutic is most common in Jewish and Roman Catholic interpretive traditions. For example, Kabbalists believe there is a mystical meaning to the Hebrew Scriptures, which can only be unlocked by decoding secret clues in the text. The Catholic Church holds similar views, understanding specific keywords and phrases as mystical references to the Christian's eternal destiny. Another example, perhaps more familiar to evangelicals, is those who attempt to calculate the Day of the Lord. They pore through the Scriptures, forming hypotheses about the date when Jesus will return to earth. These are ultimately anagogical readings of the Bible.

There's an important but over-emphasized truth here, too. Scripture does indeed contain some fascinating patterns, genealogies, and literary devices. For example, Psalm 119 is an acrostic; each section starts with the next letter in the Hebrew alphabet to convey the fullness of God's Word. Just like contemporary poetry, the Psalms and Proverbs are full of double meanings, turns of speech, and chiastic structures. Biblical

names are also laden with meaning. God spoke to the people of Israel through the names of Isaiah's sons, Shear-Jashub ("A remnant shall return") and Maher-Shalal-Hash-Baz ("Swift is the spoil, speedy is the prey"). And it's no accident that our Lord was given the names Emmanuel ("God with us") and Jesus (a Hellenized form of Joshua, meaning "God saves").

There are even times when a text may have a higher, mystical interpretation. In Hebrews 9:1-5, the author alludes to the metaphysical meaning behind the instruments of Temple worship (and then, frustratingly, says, *"but of these things we cannot now speak in detail"*). And in Genesis 49:10, when Jacob is blessing his sons, he alludes prophetically to the Messiah, calling him "Shiloh." In such instances, an anagogical sense is indeed present, and we must not ignore it. However, this is not how we are to interpret all of Scripture.

> **Theological Hermeneutic** – *A theology-driven reading, interpreting individual passages of Scripture in the light of theological presuppositions.*

This one sounds good, doesn't it? We like theology, and we like hermeneutics. So why not do them both together? Well, if we were perfect beings, our minds un-corrupted by the Fall, perhaps we could. But this side of heaven, we are prone to intellectual error. We tend to read the Scriptures with a kind of confirmation bias, always interpreting new evidence as confirmation of our pre-existing theological beliefs. In reality, we must work to avoid this. We want to derive our theology from the text, not impose our theology on the text.

One example of this would be excessive typology. In the Bible, a "type" is an Old Testament character, object, or situation that foreshadows something in the New Testament or the Church. There are plenty of types in the Bible. The Scriptures explicitly identify Adam, Noah, Melchizedek, Isaac, Moses, Aaron, David, Solomon,

and others as types of Christ. The Old Testament sacrificial system typifies the atonement that Christ fulfilled in His death on the cross. The Scriptures themselves establish and explain the significance of such typological events. But an overly theological hermeneutic would "go beyond what is written" (1 Corinthians 4:6) and attempt to find types in every story. In this view, every morally upright protagonist is a type of Christ. Every action in David's life (even those which were sinful!) must parallel something positive in the work of Christ. Because this approach goes too far, some have called it "excessive typology."

Another example would be extreme eschatology. There are lots of opinions about the "end times," and I'll spare you mine. But in this area of study, individual texts are often overshadowed by theological presuppositions. If you hold a more dispensational view, you'll tend to read prophecies about Israel's future more literally. If you have a more covenantal view, you might see those prophecies as fulfilled in Christ or the New Testament Church. But on both sides of the debate, there's often a tendency to read theological presuppositions into the text. A New Testament passage about the sobering reality of future judgment becomes a sermon series on the order of events in the last days. An Old Testament text about Israel's return from Babylon becomes a message about international missions in the Church.

In *Toward an Exegetical Theology*, Walt Kaiser warns us about an overly theological hermeneutic. "In no way may a theological grid be arbitrarily dropped over the text as a substitute for a diligent search for a unifying theological principle through the process of induction. Simply to impose a theological grid on the text must be condemned as the mark of a foolish and lazy exegete."

Summary

None of these imbalanced views contain the nuance and balance necessary. The Literal Historical Grammatic hermeneutic is the most logical, consistent way to read Scripture. As we continue to the next level of our pyramid, we'll continue to flesh out the implications of this view for the study of God's Word.

Scripture References

- Psalm 119:160
- Habakkuk 2:2-3
- Matthew 4:1-17
- Mark 12:24
- Luke 6:3-4
- Luke 10:25-29
- John 12:41
- Acts 8:28-35
- Romans 15:4
- 2 Corinthians 3:14-16
- Hebrew 4:12
- 1 Peter 1:10-12

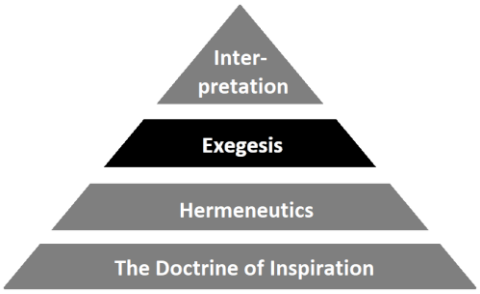
Discussion Questions

1. Read 2 Peter 1:19-21 again. What would it look like to treat your personal experience as "more sure" than Scripture? How would these verses speak to that?
2. How would adopting a literal, historical, grammatical hermeneutic impact your Bible study?
3. Have you ever read the Bible with an imbalanced hermeneutic? If so, which one and why?

Recommended Reading

- *How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth* by Gordon Fee and Douglas Stuart
- *The Hermeneutics of the Biblical Writers* by Abner Chou

4. Exegesis



As we advance to the next level of our pyramid, remember our definition of **Exegesis:** *The process used to determine the interpretation of a text.* We are now moving from the principles of Bible study into the process of Bible study. And as we dive in, we'll find that our view of hermeneutics dictates our exegetical procedures.

The word "exegesis" is an English transliteration of the Greek term *exegeomai*. It means "to lead out, to set forth in great detail, to expound," referring to the process of finding meaning in a text. Inspiration is how God put meaning into the text, and hermeneutics are our principles for pinpointing that meaning. Exegesis, then, is the actual act of extracting that meaning from a given text.

In this chapter, I'll take a slightly different approach. This chapter will be more "show" than "tell." I want to exegete a passage about exegesis. (Meta, right?) We'll not only learn from the text itself, but we'll also learn from our treatment of the text. And that text is Nehemiah 8.

> *"(1) And all the people gathered as one man at the square which was in front of the Water Gate, and they asked Ezra the scribe to bring the book of the law of*

Moses which the Lord had given to Israel. Then Ezra the priest brought the law before all the assembly of men, women, and all who could listen with understanding, on the first day of the seventh month… (7) Also Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin, Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah, Maaseiah, Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, Pelaiah, the Levites, explained the law to the people while the people remained in their place. They read from the book, from the law of God, translating to give the sense so that they understood the reading."

Context

This passage is laden with context. And without a reasonable understanding of that context, it can be challenging to find anything meaningful here. So let's discuss it.

The Israelites had just returned from seventy years of captivity. A lot can change in seventy years! Babylon had enslaved Israel, and then Persia had conquered Babylon. These waves of pagan influence had no small effect on the Israelite minority. Their captivity forced them to adapt to their new circumstances in several ways.

When the invaders destroyed Solomon's Temple, the core elements of Jewish worship came to a screeching halt, including the priestly and sacrificial systems. Instead of Hebrew, many Jews began to speak Aramaic, the common tongue in their new home. The religious leaders faced a dilemma. How could they remain faithful in a foreign land without their central place of worship? They began meeting in small community forums instead of a large assembly. In each location, elders would read the Scriptures and expound upon them. These local meetings eventually became known as synagogues.

Once the Jews returned to their land, they were reluctant to resettle the long-abandoned ruins of Jerusalem. The city was unsafe. Surrounding nations had already filled the power vacuum that arose in Israel's absence, and other people groups had seized their

old towns and farmlands. Even with Persia's blessing, they became the object of constant scorn, suspicion, and espionage. Their struggle to maintain a Hebrew identity did not ease upon their return.

But God raised up two men who led Israel into a period of revival. The first was Nehemiah, an able statesman and organizer. Serving under king Cyrus of Persia, Nehemiah was appointed governor of the newly-formed vassal state of Israel. He organized the rebuilding of Jerusalem, introduced labor reforms, and guarded against political treachery from jealous neighbors. The second man was Ezra.

Ezra was a priest and a scribe. A priest was someone who served in the Temple, presiding over the sacrifices and maintaining the instruments of worship. But as I mentioned, there was no Temple at this time. So, in keeping with the synagogue model of the period, Ezra was also a scribe. A scribe was someone who studied the Scriptures for a living. A scribe was a scholar, a teacher, someone intimately familiar with the Hebrew language and every detail of the law. In a time when the Israelites had grown disconnected from their religious roots, God used Ezra's expert knowledge of the Scriptures to lead the people back to Him.

That's the context leading up to Nehemiah 8.

Does that seem like an unnecessary amount of information? It isn't! I've done this on purpose to demonstrate the importance of context. You see, it will be difficult to grasp the meaning of Nehemiah 8 without an understanding of Israel's captivity, return, and struggle for identity. With all this context in mind, let's read it once again. Notice how a little context brings the story to life.

Explanation

> *"(1) And all the people gathered as one man at the square which was in front of the Water Gate, and they asked Ezra the scribe to bring the book of the law of Moses which the Lord had given to Israel. Then Ezra the priest brought the law before the assembly of men, women and all who could listen with understanding, on the first day of the seventh month… (7) Also Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin, Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah, Maaseiah, Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, Pelaiah, the Levites, explained the law to the people while the people remained in their place. They read from the book, from the law of God, translating to give the sense so that they understood the reading."*

It was not a fraction of the people who gathered. And they did not assemble reluctantly. Instead, we read that **"all the people gathered as one man."** This event was the beginning of a spiritual revival in Israel. The days of their splintered, fragmented, oppressed existence in Babylon and Persia were over. In a way that their foreign oppressors had never permitted, they assembled *en masse*, with one heart and mind, no longer a minority group but the majority group.

They gathered **"at the square which was in front of the Water Gate."** They couldn't have made such a statement six months earlier. Not long ago, the walls, houses, and gates that framed their assembly had laid in shambles. But under the leadership of Nehemiah, they had rebuilt Jerusalem. Despite constant political pressure to abandon the project, the entire nation could assemble in the restored ruins of their capital city.

And what was the purpose of their meeting? You might expect them to celebrate the end of construction, to rest on their laurels, or pat themselves on the back. Instead, **"they asked Ezra the scribe to bring the book of the Law of Moses."** They were coming from a place of humility. The Scriptures were not imposed upon them by the

higher-ups; they were asking for it. They knew they needed to return to God and His Word. But what drove this conviction? Why ask for this book?

Because this was a book **"which the Lord had given to Israel."** They acknowledged the inspiration of the Scriptures. They wanted to understand and obey that which God had revealed to them. Their attitude embodied Deuteronomy 29:29, *"The secret things belong to the Lord our God, but the things revealed belong to us and to our sons forever, that we may observe all the words of this law."*

This revival revolved around the Scriptures, so **"Ezra the priest brought the law."** In the previous sentence, Ezra was called a scribe. But here he is called a priest. Ezra's religious leadership involved these two crucial roles. As a scribe, he led Israel in an accurate understanding of the Scriptures. And as a priest, he led them in an appropriate response to the Scriptures. His leadership encompassed both teaching and worship.

The goal of this gathering was for God's people to understand God's Word. It was not a strategy session, limited to influential men and military leaders. It was not an all-hands meeting for the construction effort, limited to able-bodied men. This gathering was an **"assembly of men, women, and all who could listen with understanding."** Comprehension was the only qualification that mattered.

This event took place **"on the first day of the seventh month."** Back in Leviticus 23:24-25, God ordained a restful, worshipful holiday on this exact date. *"In the seventh month on the first of the month you shall have a rest, a reminder by blowing of trumpets, a holy convocation. You shall not do any laborious work, but you shall present an offering by fire to the Lord."* Nine days later, they were to celebrate Yom Kippur, the Day of Atonement. And four days after that, they were to celebrate Sukkot, the Feast of Booths. After seventy years in a foreign land, the freedom to once again observe these festivals was a reminder of God's deliverance.

Skipping down to verse 7, we read a long list of hard-to-pronounce names. **"Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin, Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah, Maaseiah, Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, Pelaiah, the Levites."** The Levites were a clan of priests who traditionally worked in the Temple and maintained the sacrificial system. But since the Temple's destruction, the nature of their work had morphed. As the synagogue model developed, the Levites became responsible for explaining God's Word to the people – and that's just what they did next.

First, the people stood for the reading of God's Word. Verse 3 says Ezra read the Scriptures *"from early morning until midday,"* around five hours of reading. (And we start getting antsy when a sermon lasts longer than an hour!) But that wasn't the whole event. **"The people remained in their place"** while the thirteen Levites **"explained the law to the people."** Simply reading wasn't enough; they needed someone to explain it. They had to dig deeper to understand what they had heard.

That's the nature of exegesis. The people spent seventy years in exile, growing apart from the language and culture of their ancestors. So when Ezra read the Scriptures in the original Hebrew, they needed to perform exegesis. They needed someone "to lead out, to set forth in great detail, to expound" upon what Ezra read. Verse 8 tells us that these Levites were **"translating to give the sense so that they understood the reading."**

Their goal was not to simply preach sermons because they liked to. Their goal was not to show off their Hebrew language skills as if Aramaic speakers weren't spiritual enough. And their goal was not to keep the people entertained. Their goal was to help the people understand their Bibles!

That's exegesis.

The people couldn't expect to understand the text immediately. So much had changed. They had to reacquaint themselves with Mosaic literature, recall its historical and

religious context, and translate the text into their contemporary Aramaic vernacular. In other words, they had to draw meaning out of the Scriptures according to a literal, historical, grammatical hermeneutic.

Clarity

In this chapter, I've tried to model a simple interpretive process.

First, we tried reading our passage with no context. Then we took a step back. We immersed ourselves in the context of Nehemiah 8 before rereading it. And the second time, it (hopefully) leaped off the page in new ways! As we examined each detail, we were able to extract more precise meaning.

In Nehemiah 8, the Jews had to bridge the gap created by seventy years' distance from the text. In the same way, we must also bridge the gap between the Scriptures and our own cultural context. The difference is: we're dealing with a lot more than seventy years! Therefore, we have to work even harder to understand the literary, historical, and grammatical context of the Bible. This fact leads to an important principle I want you to understand.

Getting to authorial intent takes hard work!

Now, a word of clarification is in order. I don't mean that Scripture is unclear. On the contrary: Scripture is indeed clear and understandable. You can read your Bible and be confident that it means what it says. However, there are two different kinds of "clear."

Consider the equation **2 + 2 = 4**. That is a clear statement. It's also very simple, easily graspable; you can demonstrate it to a toddler with Cheerios.

Now consider the equation **e = mc²**. That is also a clear statement. Its meaning is not ambiguous; it communicates a specific concept in universal terms. But it's not very simple. It may take years of study to grasp it. And, to the best of my current knowledge, you can't demonstrate Einstein's Theory of Relativity with Cheerios.

The Bible is indeed clear, but it's not always simple. Even the Apostle Peter admitted that some Scriptures were *"hard to understand"* (2 Peter 3:16). Getting to authorial intent takes hard work. But the hard work of exegesis is well worth the effort!

Significance

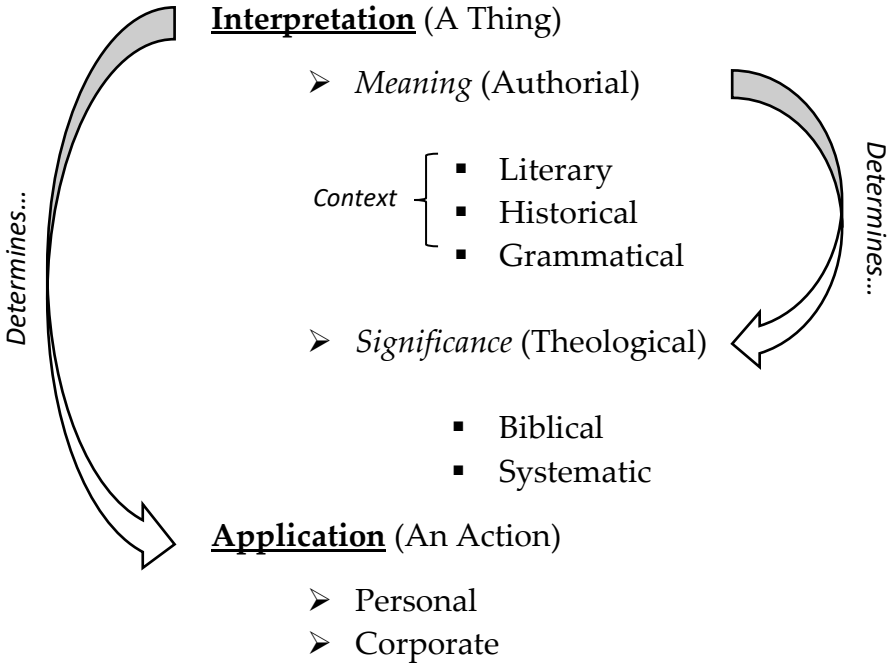
Let's look at one more example, this time from the New Testament. In Acts 8:29-36, Philip has a fascinating interaction with an Ethiopian eunuch. I won't spend much time on this one. I simply want to demonstrate that, 500 years after the events of Nehemiah 8, the process of extracting meaning from the text had remained largely the same.

> *"Then the Spirit said to Philip, 'Go up and join this chariot.' Philip ran up and heard him reading Isaiah the prophet, and said, 'Do you understand what you are reading?' And he said, 'Well, how could I, unless someone guides me?' And he invited Philip to come up and sit with him. Now the passage of Scripture which he was reading was this: 'He was led as a sheep to slaughter; and as a lamb before its shearer is silent, so He does not open His mouth. In humiliation His judgment was taken away; who will relate to his generation? For His life is removed from the earth.' The eunuch answered Philip and said, 'Please tell me, of whom does the prophet say this? Of himself or someone else?' Then Philip opened his mouth, and beginning from this Scripture he preached Jesus to him."*

The Ethiopian eunuch was struggling to understand the Scriptures. Because he was missing the full context of the 700-year-old prophecy in Isaiah 53, he couldn't answer

some crucial questions about the text. And notice how Philip responded. He explained the text's meaning (authorial intent), but he didn't stop there. He also explained its full theological significance and then applied it, encouraging the Ethiopian to be baptized.

These distinctions are essential. The context, meaning, significance, and application of a text are all different things. When we confuse them, we tend to misunderstand, misappropriate, and misapply the Scriptures. But sound exegesis seeks to align these elements according to a literal historical grammatical hermeneutic. I like to diagram it like this:



We'll talk about application later, but I want you to see how this all fits together.

We avoid an "Overly Theological" hermeneutic (see chapter 3) by anchoring ourselves in the original author's literary, historical, and grammatical context. This is necessary for sound exegesis. But once we understand the authorial intent of the text, we must not

neglect its broader theological significance. You see, biblical and systematic theology are still crucial for interpreting the Bible; they're just not the right starting place.

Philip models this in Acts 8:28-36. He explained the meaning of Isaiah's prophecy and then took it all the way home. The answer to the Ethiopian's question – *"Of whom does the prophet speak?"* – was inherently connected to the broader theological significance of Isaiah 53.

"Surely our griefs He Himself bore, and our sorrows He carried; yet we ourselves esteemed Him stricken, smitten of God, and afflicted. But He was pierced through for our transgressions, He was crushed for our iniquities; the chastening for our well-being fell upon Him, and by His scourging we are healed. All of us like sheep have gone astray, each of us has turned to his own way; but the Lord has caused the iniquity of us all to fall on Him."

And then, the section the Ethiopian was struggling with, "*He was oppressed and He was afflicted, yet He did not open His mouth; like a lamb that is led to slaughter, and like a sheep that is silent before its shearers, so He did not open His mouth. By oppression and judgment He was taken away; and as for His generation, who considered that He was cut off out of the land of the living for the transgression of my people, to whom the stroke was due?"*

Isaiah wrote about the substitutionary atonement necessary to deliver God's people from judgment, and yet this suffering servant's identity had been a mystery until Christ. But Philip had the whole picture, the broader story, the big idea. So when the Ethiopian asked him who the verse was referring to, he didn't hesitate to interpret the text fully. *"Beginning from this Scripture He preached Jesus to him."* Philip explained not only the authorial intent but also the broader theological significance of the text.

That's exegesis.

Summary

When we study our Bibles, we're engaging in a work that God's people have been doing for thousands of years. We're exerting ourselves to holistically discover the context, meaning, and significance of the Scriptures. Both Old Testament and New Testament saints have upheld this process. We can trust it!

So far, we've discussed inspiration, hermeneutics, and exegesis. These chapters have been mostly theoretical – exposing you to terms and concepts. But as we reach the final level of our pyramid, we'll bring together everything we've learned and get very practical.

Scripture References

- Psalm 119:97
- Isaiah 34:16
- Matthew 13:52
- John 5:39
- Acts 17:1-3
- Acts 17:11
- Acts 28:23
- 2 Timothy 2:15
- 1 Peter 1:10-12
- Hebrews 5:11-14

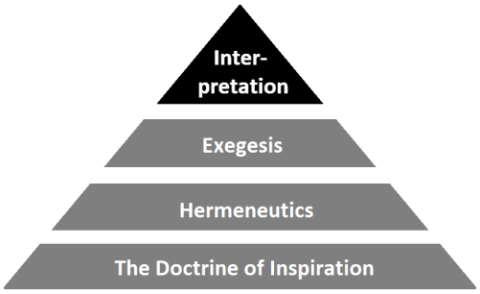
Discussion Questions

1. If "getting to authorial intent is hard work," what does that mean for your personal Bible study?
2. What role does context play in interpretation? How would you incorporate this into your study?
3. Why is it important to distinguish between a text's meaning, significance, and application?

Recommended Reading

- *Reading the Bible Supernaturally* by John Piper
- *Toward an Exegetical Theology* by Walter C. Kaiser Jr.

5. Asking the Text



At the fourth and final level of our pyramid, we're bringing it all together. We'll leverage what we've learned about the principles of hermeneutics and the process of exegesis to help us actually interpret the Scriptures. Remember our definition of **Interpretation:** *A judgment as to the meaning of a text.*

The whole goal of this book is to bridge the gap between beginner Bible study techniques and advanced seminary studies. You don't need to know Greek or get a degree to study your Bible confidently. And I firmly believe that hermeneutics and exegesis matter for ordinary Christians. I want you to feel empowered, not overwhelmed. So, in the remaining chapters, we're going to get very practical.

In my experience, one of the best ways to study the Bible is to *ask questions of the text*. I keep a list of questions in my Bible. I nearly always use them when exploring a passage. These questions help me press into the right areas and avoid focusing on topics that aren't the passage's main point.

I ask four "primary" questions, which are listed below.

(1) What did this text mean to the human author?

(2) What does this text teach me about God?

(3) How should this text contribute to my theology?

(4) How does that truth apply to me?

Each of these primary questions contains several "subordinate" questions. We'll walk through each of these in detail, including biblical examples for each. The complete, bulleted list is available for your convenience in Appendix A.

(1) What did this text mean to the human author?

This first question aims to discover the authorial intent of the passage. Under this heading, each subordinate question helps us identify relevant context related to the human author. As we look at these questions, notice how correctly identifying contextual details can cast a passage in an entirely new light.

(1A) Who were they?

Who was the human author of this text? What biographical information do we know about them?

Jesus Himself modeled the importance of this question in Matthew 22:41-46. *"Now while the Pharisees were gathered together, Jesus asked them a question: 'What do you think about the Christ, whose son is He?' They said to Him, 'The son of David.' He said to them, 'Then how does David in the Spirit call Him "Lord," saying, "The Lord said to my Lord, sit at My right hand, until I put your enemies beneath your feet?" If David calls Him "Lord," how is He His son? No one was able to answer Him a word, nor did anyone dare from that day on to ask Him another question."*

Jesus made His point by correctly identifying the author of Psalm 116.

In this psalm, the author refers to the Messiah as his "Lord." This designation is a sign of submission. If someone is your "Lord," that means you're their servant! By correctly identifying the author, Jesus proved that David – the King of Israel and patriarch of the Messianic line - viewed this promised savior as his superior. The Christ is more than the Son of Adam, Abraham, and David; He is also the Son of God.

Jesus made this powerful argument on a single interpretive observation: that the author of Psalm 116 is David. We should be asking this question every time we study the Bible. Who is the human author of this text? What do we know about them? And how does that impact the meaning and overall significance of the text?

(It's important to mention: we don't always have full answers to these questions! For example, ask ten biblical scholars, "who's the author of Hebrews?" You'll get ten different answers. At the end of the day, it's all speculation; we just don't know. However, we can still infer meaningful biographical information about them from their writings, even if it is somewhat vague.)

(1B) When did they write this?

The Bible is ancient literature, and understanding its historical context is essential. At what point in history was this passage written? What was going on historically, politically, and culturally?

In Ezekiel 19:1, God tells Ezekiel to *"take up a lamentation for the princes of Israel."* This word "lamentation" is *qinah* in Hebrew – a funeral song, a lament, a dirge – evoking the same sad lyrical qualities as Jeremiah's "Book of Lamentations" written in the same period. In chapter 19, Ezekiel pens a mournful dirge for two princes of Judah: Jehoahaz II and his brother Zedekiah. We know from 2 Kings and 2 Chronicles that both suffered

an awful end. Three months into his reign, the Egyptian Pharaoh captured Jehoahaz and exiled him permanently. While Zedekiah survived slightly longer, we read in 2 Kings 25:7 about his terrible fate at the hands of Nebuchadnezzar. *"They slaughtered the sons of Zedekiah before his eyes, then put out the eyes of Zedekiah and bound him with bronze fetters and brought him to Babylon."* In verse 14, Ezekiel's funeral song ends with a reiterative, resigned sigh, *"This is a lamentation, and has become a lamentation."*

But there's more to uncover here. You see, Ezekiel meticulously recorded the year and date of every prophecy he proclaimed. Each chronological section of the book starts with a detailed timestamp. Thanks to this structure, we know Ezekiel wrote chapter 19 sometime between "the sixth year" and "the seventh year" of his own exile in Babylon. Now, we also have access to the dates and timelines mentioned in 2 Kings. If we cross-reference Ezekiel 1:2, 8:1, and 20:1 with 2 Kings 24:15-18 and 25:2, we come to a surprising realization. Ezekiel wrote this "funeral song" 3-4 years *before* Nebuchadnezzar humiliated and exiled Zedekiah. The lament in chapter 19 wasn't looking back on past events; it was anticipating future events!

That changes the tone of the chapter quite dramatically, doesn't it? It's one thing to give a eulogy after someone has died. But it's an entirely different thing to start singing songs about someone who's still alive as if they're already dead! Suddenly, this passage becomes less about mourning and more about warning. God is warning the exiles not to put their hope in political deliverance. Kings will fall, and princes will pass away. God is their only hope now.

If we didn't do the hard work of correctly identifying the time of writing, we would miss this crucial nuance. We should ask this question whenever we study a text. When did the author write this? What was going on in that period?

(1C) Where did they live?

The Bible is full of diverse places, nations, and people groups. When we study a text, we should dig into these areas. What geographical context informed this passage? Where was the author from originally? Where did they live?

Consider Psalm 137. *"(1) By the rivers of Babylon, there we sat down and wept, when remembered Zion… (3) For there our captors demanded of us songs, and our tormentors mirth, saying, 'Sing us one of the songs of Zion.' How can we sing the Lord's song in a foreign land? If I forget you, O Jerusalem, may my right hand forget its skill."*

This is one of the few psalms (perhaps the only one) written in Babylon. The Israelites are an oppressed minority. We've already learned about Israel's defeat, exile, and struggle for identity. This psalm verbalizes the anguish of genocide, the shame of national defeat, the loss of a culture, and the pain of seeing Temple worship eradicated. We won't see these themes unless we consider the geographical context of the author.

(1D) What were they addressing?

This question aims to discover the author's purpose in writing. What topics was the author commenting on? What events were they reacting to? What circumstances led them to write this text? I'll give you a straightforward example.

Jeremiah 29:11 says, *"'For I know the plans that I have for you,' declares the Lord, 'plans for welfare and not for calamity to give you a future and a hope.'"*

This verse is often taken out of context. But if we simply go back one verse, we learn what Jeremiah was addressing. *"(10) For thus says the Lord, 'When seventy years have been completed for Babylon, I will visit you and fulfill My good word to you, to bring you back to this*

place.'" Jeremiah was addressing Israel's despair as they went into exile. He delivered a specific promise from the Lord: this will not be forever – after seventy years have passed, I will rescue you from Babylon and bring you back into Israel.

This verse does indeed apply to us today – it just applies to us indirectly. We're not ancient Israelites, we're not Babylonian slaves, and God hasn't promised us freedom after seventy years. These particular promises weren't given to us. But this verse does tell us something about God: it tells us that God is faithful to keep His promises. And there certainly are plenty of promises that we have received as New Testament believers. Jeremiah 29:11 is one of many examples proving God's faithfulness to His people. We worship the same God that brought Israel out of Egypt and Babylon. We can trust His promises.

(1E) What was in *their* Bible?

We must remember that the Bible was written over a period of 1,500 years. God revealed His Word progressively. Until the Apostle John penned the final "Amen" in Revelation 22:21, no single author had access to the complete canon of Scripture. John had "more Bible" than James did, Paul had more than Isaiah, who had more than David, and so on.

We must consider a passage's placement in the timeline of progressive revelation. How much of the Bible did the author have? Which other books existed at that point? What Scriptures could they quote, allude to, or reference?

For example, let's look at 2 Timothy 4:6. *"For I am already being poured out as a drink offering, and the time of my departure has come."*

In this verse, Paul alludes to Leviticus 23 and Numbers 15, which describe the "libation offering" or "drink offering." While presenting a burnt sacrifice, priests would pour

sweet wine over the roasting meat to enhance the aroma. The wine was valuable and time-consuming to produce, so pouring it out before the Lord was a way to honor Him sacrificially.

When Paul wanted to describe his final days, he looked to his Bible for illustrative imagery. And his Bible was the Old Testament. (He probably also had access to the books of James, Mark, and Luke, in addition to his own epistles.) At the end of it all, he compares his life to a libation offering. His impending death reminded him of sweet wine poured out upon a sacrifice – a mere garnish.

(2) What does this text teach me about God?

This second "primary" question observes how God reveals Himself through His Word. This question embraces the dual authorship of Scripture. How has God communicated Himself in this text? What do we learn about Him?

This time, let's stick with a single passage. Once we've run through our subordinate questions, we'll summarize our findings. Exodus 34:6-7 is laden with beautiful theology; let's see what it teaches us about God.

"Then the Lord passed by in front of [Moses] and proclaimed, 'The Lord, the Lord God, compassionate and gracious, slow to anger, and abounding in lovingkindness and truth; who keeps lovingkindness for thousands, who forgives iniquity, transgression, and sin; yet He will by no means leave the guilty unpunished, visiting the iniquity of the fathers on the children and on the grandchildren to the third and fourth generations."

(A) What is God saying or doing in this text?

This question aims to identify God's action or communication. What's God up to in this text? That's not always easy to answer. Sometimes God isn't directly mentioned in a passage, so you may need to think about it for a while. But in Exodus 34:6-7, this question has a straightforward answer.

God is revealing Himself to Moses. He's describing Himself, declaring who He is. After calling Himself *"The Lord, the Lord God,"* He goes on to list His own attributes.

(B) Why is God saying or doing this?

This question aims to identify God's purpose in doing what He's doing. What is His motivation in this text? What prompted this action or communication? Of course, there's always an ultimate answer for why God does anything: for the sake of His own glory! But this question is looking for intermediate purposes. Are there any specific reasons listed? Has God revealed His particular motivations for us to study?

In this case, we have a relatively straightforward answer. A few verses back, Moses asked God to reveal Himself. According to Exodus 33:18, *"Moses said, 'I pray You, show me Your glory!"* So, why is God revealing Himself to Moses? Because Moses asked.

(C) How is God saying or doing this?

This question aims to identify God's means. Is God acting through providential or miraculous means? Is He communicating through natural or special revelation? Is He speaking directly, or through a dream, an angel, or a prophet?

In Exodus 34:6-7, God is revealing Himself in two ways. First, God is revealing Himself in physical (or at least optical) form. God hides Moses in the cleft of the rock and passes

by, somehow allowing Moses to actually see Him. And second, God is revealing Himself in verbal, descriptive form. God speaks truth about Himself, putting words to vision, declaring His nature openly.

(D) Which of God's attributes are on display in this text?

This question aims to identify God's character and nature as it appears in the text. What does this text tell us about who – and *what* – God is? When answering this question, it may be helpful to work from an organized list of "the attributes of God." You can usually find these in a systematic theology book or similar resource (more on this later.)

In Exodus 34:6-7, we learn that God is caring and sympathetic, for He calls Himself *"compassionate."*

We learn that God is generous and benevolent, for He calls Himself *"gracious."*

We learn that God is patient with weakness, for He says He is *"slow to anger."*

And we learn that God is *"abounding in"* (overflowing with) two things.

First, He is overflowing with faithfulness to His people, for He says He is *"abounding in lovingkindness."*

And second, He is overflowing with faithfulness to Himself, for He says He is *"abounding in truth."*

We learn that God desires and delights in forgiveness, for He declares Himself a God who *"forgives iniquity, transgression, and sin."*

But at the same time, we learn that God is holy, just, and all-powerful, for He says that He *"will by no means leave the guilty unpunished."*

And we learn that God stands in relationship to the entire human race, for He says that He *"will visit the iniquity of the fathers"* on later generations.

What a theologically rich passage! By asking these subordinate questions, we've identified the actions, purpose, means, and character of God revealed in Exodus 34:6-7. Now we can revisit the primary question and summarize our findings.

So, **what does this text teach me about God?**

This text teaches me that God wants to be known – and known accurately. God is revealing Himself visually and describing Himself verbally. He is disclosing Himself to Moses in unique and precise ways.

This text teaches me that God must be related to rightly – and that sin prevents that. God reveals Himself to be holy, just, and all-powerful. He defines His relationship to individuals and indeed the entire human race in terms of sin and righteousness.

And this text teaches me that God loves to express mercy, grace, and forgiveness. He is caring, patient, and faithful to fulfill His promises. He doesn't discard His people when they fail; He's loyal to them because He's faithful to Himself and His promises. As the Apostle Paul put it many millennia later, *"If we are faithless, He remains faithful, for He cannot deny Himself"* (2 Timothy 2:13).

What a powerful expression of the gospel! By asking the right questions, we can extract meaningful theological truth from the text. As we study the Scriptures, we learn about who God is – the greatest of all knowledge – and this prompts us to love and worship Him more.

(3) How should this text contribute to my theology?

This question aims to understand an individual text as part of a cohesive whole. We're now shifting from discovering the meaning of a text (its authorial intent) to identifying

its significance (its broader theological implications). Both are necessary for interpretation.

Let's look at another Old Testament example, Exodus 26:31-33.

"You shall make a veil of blue and purple and scarlet material and fine twisted linen; it shall be made with cherubim, the work of a skillful workman. You shall hang it on four pillars of acacia overlaid with gold, their hooks also being of gold, on four sockets of silver. You shall hang up the veil under the clasps, and shall bring in the ark of the testimony there within the veil; and the veil shall serve for you as a partition between the holy place and the holy of holies."

(A) How does this text advance the metanarrative of Scripture?

Let me first define **Metanarrative:** *the overarching story comprised of and connecting smaller stories.*

If you've read or watched the Harry Potter series, you're already familiar with this concept. Each story in the series is mostly self-contained. But each consecutive entry develops the overarching story. Themes, settings, and characters reappear and intersect in interesting ways throughout the series. The lore and plot expand into something more significant and exciting than any single entry by itself. That overarching story is the series' metanarrative.

The Bible works similarly. Each book of the Bible has its own context, characters, themes, genre, and sub-plot. But God's telling a story that's bigger than any single book on its own. From Moses to John, each consecutive revelation develops this overarching story: the story of redemption. This question aims to understand how any given text develops that story.

So how does Exodus 26:31-33 advance the metanarrative of Scripture?

Well, it picks up on the theme of separation between man and God. *"The veil shall serve for you as a partition between the holy place and the holy of holies."* It served a very functional purpose: preventing human priests from looking upon The Presence. But it had a symbolic purpose, too.

The veil was one of many artistic works adorning the Tabernacle, and the imagery crafted into those pieces was significant. In a space occupied by God's Presence, the decorative use of pomegranates and cherubim was no accident – it reminds us of the Garden of Eden. Do you remember the state in which God left the Garden? After banishing Adam and Eve for eating the forbidden fruit, *"He stationed the cherubim and the flaming sword which turned every direction to guard the way to the tree of life"* (Genesis 3:24).

The imagery of the veil was intentional. It reminds us of what prevents humanity from enjoying perfect communion with God. The Tabernacle was "theological architecture." The structure, furniture, decorations, and materials communicated something specific about God. And in this case, Exodus 26:31-33 advances the metanarrative of Scripture by developing the theme of separation between man and God.

(B) How does this text point to Christ?

The veil symbolizes the problem Christ came to solve: humans cannot approach God. And it was God Himself who commissioned the veil with its meaningful imagery, and indeed the whole sacrificial system that directs us to Christ. In Galatians 3:4, Paul says that *"the law has become our tutor to lead us to Christ, so that we may be justified by faith."* The veil illustrates the problem, and the sacrifices demonstrate the solution.

(C) What other passages of Scripture clarify and/or illustrate this text?

Think about Matthew 27:50-51. *"And Jesus cried out with a loud voice, and yielded up His spirit. And behold, the veil of the temple was torn in two from top to bottom; and the earth shook and the rocks were split."*

As Jesus hung on the cross, as the metanarrative of Scripture reached its heart-wrenching climax, the narrator (Matthew) takes us across Jerusalem, into the Temple, to look at the torn veil. Think about that! When Christ gave His life as a perfect sacrifice for us, the curse of Eden was lifted at that very moment. The veil representing the separation between God and man was supernaturally torn in two. It wasn't torn from the bottom up (as if from man to God), but from the top down - salvation wrought by God on man's behalf.

And consider Hebrews 6:19-20. *"This hope we have as an anchor of the soul, a hope both sure and steadfast and one which enters within the veil, where Jesus has entered as a forerunner for us, having become a high priest forever according to the order of Melchizedek."*

This verse ties the hope of our salvation to the theology of the veil. We only have communion with God because Jesus entered into the holy of holies before us. Through His sacrificial death and righteous resurrection, Jesus has become to us a sure and steadfast hope. We can trust that God will not refuse us from His presence because Jesus has gone before us and invited us into fellowship with Him.

And what about Hebrews 10:19-22? *"Therefore, brethren, since we have confidence to enter the holy place by the blood of Jesus, by a new and living way which He inaugurated for us through the veil, that is, His flesh, and since we have a great priest over the house of God, let us draw near with a sincere heart in full assurance of faith, having our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water."*

Our hope in Jesus produces confidence before God. We don't need to be afraid of God! Jesus has made us friends of God, confident in our relationship with Him, and servants

of God confident in our ministry to Him. *"We are not of those who shrink back to destruction, but of those who have faith to the preserving of the soul"* (Hebrews 10:39).

This obscure passage about fabric in Exodus 26 leads us to the highest, most glorious truths of the gospel. By asking what other passages of Scripture clarify or illustrate this text, we break into a vibrant world of significance. We are enlivened in our faith by the simplest texts when we subject them to the whole counsel of God.

(D) Which areas of systematic theology relate to this text?

If you've ever read a systematic theology book (for example, Wayne Grudem's *Systematic Theology*), you'll recognize various categories of theology typically represented in such works. These vary somewhat from author to author, but they generally look something like this:

- Bibliology (the study of the Bible)
- Theology Proper (the study of God)
- Christology (the study of Christ)
- Pneumatology (the study of the Spirit)
- Angelology (the study of angels)
- Anthropology (the study of man)
- Hamartiology (the study of sin)
- Soteriology (the study of salvation)
- Ecclesiology (the study of the Church)
- Eschatology (the study of the end)

This question seeks to identify which areas of study are related to the passage at hand. Answering this helps ensure that our interpretation of one individual passage is cohesive with the whole system of thought proposed by God's Word.

So, in Exodus 26, which areas of systematic theology relate to this text?

First of all, we see *Theology Proper* and *Anthropology*. It is because God is holy and men are sinful that the veil is necessary. It will probably prove insightful to study the Bible's theology of God and man systematically.

We also find *Angelology* in the decorative depictions of the cherubim. What exactly are cherubim? Why are they associated with the Garden, the Temple, and the Throne of God? Since the veil included depictions of them, what did they look like?

We see a connection to *Soteriology*, as well. One cross-reference refers to our salvation as something that Christ *"inaugurated for us through the veil, that is, His flesh"* (Hebrews 10:20). Why does Hebrews equate the veil to Jesus' flesh? Another cross-reference tells us that Old Testament Temple decorations were simply *"copies of the things in the heavens,"* and that *"Christ did not enter a holy place made with hands, a mere copy of the true one, but into heaven itself, now to appear in the presence of God for us"* (Hebrews 9:23-24). In what way is the veil a copy of something in heaven? What exactly did Christ enter, and when? And how is this connected to our salvation?

We also see a hint of *Ecclesiology* since several New Testament passages describe the Church and believers using imagery from the Tabernacle and Temple (1 Cor 3:16-17, 6:19-20, 1 Pet 2:4-8). How has worship changed under the New Covenant? What has stayed the same? If Christ reconciled God and man, is there any ongoing significance to the "Holy of Holies" concept in Christian worship today?

There are probably more connections to be found, but those struck me as the obvious ones. By asking these questions, we gain access to a vast system of associated thoughts, frameworks, and theology. As we seek to interpret the Scriptures, we must not neglect their broader theological significance.

(4) How does that truth apply to me?

Last but not least, we come to application. Our first two "primary" questions deal with the authorial intent of the text, the third seeks to understand its theological significance, and this fourth question asks how these truths relate to us today. What must we do? How should this text change us?

We don't want to approach the text with a "Moral/Allegorical" hermeneutic (see Chapter 3), an application-driven reading of the text. We want to reserve our interpretive judgment until we've done the hard work of exegesis, only then deriving an application that aligns with a literal historical grammatical hermeneutic. Therefore, this final set of questions aim to understand the differences between our context and the original author's context.

Let's look at a New Testament example, 1 Corinthians 8:4-13. (I encourage you to read it all, but due to its length, I've simplified it to core arguments here.) *"(4) Therefore concerning the eating of things sacrificed to idols, we know that there is no such thing as an idol in the world, and that there is no God but one… (7) However not all men have this knowledge; but some, being accustomed to the idol until now, eat food as if it were sacrificed to an idol; and their conscience being weak is defiled… (13) Therefore, if food causes my brother to stumble, I will never eat meat again, so that I will not cause my brother to stumble."*

This text addresses a situation that's pretty foreign to most of us. The issue of eating meat slaughtered in a pagan ritual is not one we often encounter in 21st Century America. But these questions will help us understand how to apply this text appropriately in our own lives.

(A) What is my relationship to the human author?

Paul was a devout Jew who converted to Christ. By the time he wrote this letter, he had dedicated his whole life to reaching Gentiles with the gospel. Even though I'm living 2,000 years later, I'm a Gentile believer myself. In this way, I'm a beneficiary of Paul's evangelistic efforts. You could say that Paul is my great-grandfather in the faith.

(B) What is my relationship to the original audience?

The church at Corinth was a diverse group of Christians of different genders, races, and socio-economic statuses, all struggling to live out their faith in a big city well-known for immorality. Corinth was the Las Vegas of its time. Even though I live 5,000 miles away from Corinth, I live in a relatively metropolitan environment myself. A contemporary American city really isn't too different from an ancient Greco-Roman city; both are centers of culture, politics, business, and entertainment. And both contexts share a common cultural idol: sexuality. The spiritual struggles I encounter today are comparatively similar to those faced by the original audience of 1 Corinthians.

(C) What are the differences between my world and their world?

In 21st Century America, we can scarcely fathom just how religious everything was in ancient Corinth. Perhaps some of our Southern states feature the Ten Commandments in a prominent public display. But that infusion of religion and society pales in comparison to the ancient world. Shrines, temples, and idols lined the streets and filled people's homes; every element of society connected to the pantheon somehow.

For example, there were no grocery stores in ancient Corinth. If you wanted to buy meat, you shopped in marketplaces stocked with religious sacrifices. Local priests and priestesses would have slaughtered everything on display in pagan ceremonies for one

god or another. This reality posed an interesting dilemma for Christians who lived in Corinth.

Some Christians saw it as a sin to eat meat sacrificed to pagan gods, while others thought it was okay. In this letter, Paul wasn't so much concerned with the rightness or wrongness of buying meat at the Corinthian market. Instead, he was addressing the conflict that arose between Christians over this issue. He urged Christians to take the high path: don't cause your brother to stumble, even if they're misinformed.

Now, this exact issue doesn't exist in most contemporary Christian circles. (At least, not in the West.) However, today, there are plenty of cultural practices that some Christians see as sinful while others don't. Is it okay for Christians to drink alcohol? What movies are appropriate for a Christian to watch? These sorts of topics begin to approach the realm of application for 1 Corinthians 8.

(D) Is my relationship to God different than the original audience?

In some cases, you might well answer this "Yes!"

For example, think back to Jeremiah 29:11. In that case, the original audience lived under the law of Moses. They expressed faithfulness to God and trust in the Messiah through the sacrificial system. And as Old Testament believers, they were not indwelt by the Holy Spirit. When you think about it, their relationship with God was quite different from mine! Imagine how difficult it must have been to see the Temple demolished by Babylonian invaders. That would be a hopeless situation. The invaders had destroyed not only their home but also their only means of worshipping God. And how encouraging and hopeful it must have been to hear God say, *"I have plans to give you a future and a hope!"*

However, returning to 1 Corinthians 8, we must answer "No!" The Corinthians believers were not under the law of Moses. They were Gentiles who had received the gospel of Jesus Christ. Our relationship with God is no different than theirs. We enjoy the same spiritual status in Christ, and God desires the same expressions of worship from us both.

So, **how does this truth apply to me?** Using our answers from each of these four subordinate questions, we can answer the primary question confidently.

As a believer, I should be ready to lay down my rights and freedoms to protect the spiritual well-being of my brothers and sisters in Christ. I should care more about protecting my brother's conscience than expressing my own liberty unhindered. Depending on the cultural issue, that might mean abstaining from alcohol in certain groups, times, or locations. That might mean picking movies that everyone can enjoy together.

Now, that doesn't mean that I should accept legalism. Because Christ is my righteousness, my actions can't win any more of God's grace or incur any more of God's judgment. I'm not saved by my rightness or wrongness on cultural issues; I'm saved by faith in Jesus Christ. And that goes for my brothers and sisters, too. So, when it comes to hotly-debated cultural habits, *"each person must be fully convinced in his own mind"* because *"whatever is not from faith is sin"* (Romans 14:5, 23).

These are simple, straightforward applications of 1 Corinthians 8. We derive these applications from a commonsense reading of Scripture, and they're not difficult to discover! By asking thoughtful questions, we can confidently and accurately apply the Scriptures to our lives.

Summary

What did this text mean to the human author? What does this text teach me about God? How should this text contribute to my theology? And how does that truth apply to me?

Good questions lead to helpful answers.

I keep these questions in my Bible and use them often. And I encourage you to use them, too. You don't need to know Greek or Hebrew or have a degree in biblical studies to answer these questions. All you need is a little curiosity.

But you might be wondering: *How do I actually learn about the literary, historical, and grammatical context of the Bible? It's one thing for you to spout off facts about the Babylonian exile, but what if I don't know anything about that period? What if, like the Ethiopian eunuch, I'm asking a question that I can't answer without help?*

In these next two chapters, I'll teach you how to find those answers for yourself.

First, we'll learn one of the most crucial skills for Bible study: **outlining**. This practice will help us wrap our minds around the literary and grammatical context of a passage. And second, we'll learn how to use **extrabiblical resources**. What's the difference between a lexicon and a Bible dictionary? How should we use commentaries? And how can we confidently research the Bible's historical context without getting a Ph.D.?

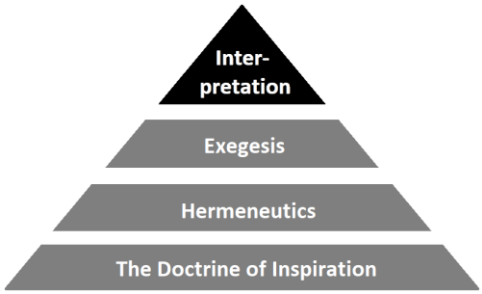
Scripture References

- Pick any passage of Scripture!

Discussion Questions

- For the passage you picked, try to answer all our "Ask the Text" questions from this chapter.
- How did these questions aid your understanding and application of that passage?
- Were there any questions you couldn't answer? Why not?

6. Outlining



When it comes to interpreting the Bible, outlining is a crucial skill. This chapter will demonstrate why outlining is essential, how to do it, and how to use outlines in our Bible study. But before we go much further, I need to define what I mean by "outlining."

> **Outlining** – *The process of notating the structure, themes, and argument flow of a book of the Bible.*

Outlining helps us discover the literary and grammatical context of an individual passage. Writing a good outline is like tracing an object's contours to depict its silhouette on paper. But writing a bad outline is like trying to force a square peg into a round hole. Good outlines reflect what's in the text; they don't try to impose a structure that isn't there.

It's also worth defining what I *don't* mean. I don't mean sermon notes (often referred to as "homiletical outlines"). And I'm not talking about a commentary or exposition, either. I mean a streamlined series of points, identifying the sections and subsections of a book.

Let me show you an example.

A Syntactical Outline of 2 Thessalonians

(1:1-4) Greetings & Thanksgiving

(1:5-3:5) Instruction Regarding the Return of Christ

(1:5-12) The Hope & Threat of Christ's Return

(2:1-17) The Timing & Implications of Christ's Return

(3:1-5) Praying for the Triumph of God's Kingdom

(3:6-15) Exhortation Regarding the Undisciplined

(3:6-10) Principle Exhortations

(3:11-15) Practical Exhortations

(3:16-18) Conclusion

I created this outline while studying 2 Thessalonians. You can see how I've parsed Paul's letter into an indented outline that highlights its structure, themes, and argument flow. This structure is called a "syntactical outline" – an analysis based on syntax.

Now, it's important to note that outlines are subjective. Mine will probably look different from yours, and they'll both probably look different from the outline in your study Bible. We might end up seeing the same major divisions across an entire book, but we may title them a bit differently.

The important thing is: if we've produced an outline, we've engaged with the literature and developed a sense of the author's message. It's essential to do this on our own. It's hard work, but it pays dividends when answering complex questions about the context of a passage.

Why Outline?

At the risk of quoting *Toward an Exegetical Theology* too often here, I want to highlight another statement by Walt Kaiser. I think this quote speaks to the importance of outlining in the interpretive process.

> *"Good exegetical procedure dictates that the details be viewed in light of the total context. Unless the exegete knows where the thought of the text begins and how that pattern develops, all the intricate details may be of little or no worth. This ability – the ability to state what each section of a book is about and how the paragraphs in that section contribute to that argument – is one of the most critical steps. If the exegete falters here, much of what follows will be wasted time and effort."*

A single blue puzzle piece could be anything: flowers, water, the sky, a bluebird. To understand what it is and where it fits, you need to understand the whole picture. And Scripture passages are like individual puzzle pieces. We must read, study, and explain those pieces as they relate to the whole.

So, why outline? I would propose three reasons why.

First, because **outlining develops authorial intent.** Remember our definition of **Authorial Intent:** *The original meaning intended by the author of a text.* Outlining helps us interpret and understand the text as God intended it to be interpreted and understood.

Second, because **outlining discovers the structure of the book.** The ancient authors didn't divide their work into digestible sections using chapter and verse markings (commentators developed these divisions several centuries after the New Testament's completion). Outlining helps us grasp the high-level themes and arguments the author used to make their point.

And third, because **outlining determines sections for concentrated study.** Do you ever sit down to study the Bible but find it difficult to identify what exactly to study? Outlining helps us figure out where to start by breaking a big book into smaller sections.

Two Critical Skills

There are two invaluable skills involved in outlining: summary and synthesis.

> **Summary** – *Condensing a lengthy, difficult, or complicated passage into a simple statement.*
>
> **Synthesis** – *Combining multiple sources, ideas, or passages to form a single argument.*

Outlining involves both of these skills working in tandem. Let me demonstrate what I mean using the example of Matthew 1-2. The skill of **Summary** takes those two chapters and condenses them down to a series of simple points:

> (1:1-17) The Genealogy of Christ
>
> (1:18-25) The Birth of Christ
>
> (2:1-12) The Visit of the Wise Men
>
> (2:13-15) The Flight to Egypt
>
> (2:16-18) Herod Kills the Children
>
> (2:19-23) Jesus Returns to Nazareth

And the skill of **Synthesis** combines these points into a single header line that captures the overall topic of the entire passage:

> (Matthew 1:1-2:23) The Advent of the King

Do you see how these skills are helpful?

By thoughtfully summarizing the Scriptures, we create a list of simplified statements reflecting the content of the text. And by repetitively synthesizing, we add structure to that list, reflecting the overall movement of the text. These two skills are invaluable as we seek to understand the literary and grammatical context of any passage.

I call them "skills" because they take practice to get good at! The more you outline the Bible, the more accurate and readable your outlines will become. So don't be discouraged if you find it challenging at first; repetition is the key to mastery!

Finding the Unit of the Text

Our first task is to divide a passage into appropriately sized pieces for outlining. Thus, we need to identify the primary unit of thought in that particular text. How does this passage naturally break down? What are the literary building blocks of the author's argument?

However, this can be challenging. That measure – the author's unit of thought – often changes from one genre to another. And the Bible contains several different genres. You might outline Matthew's gospel one way and Paul's letter to the Corinthians in an entirely different way. In the section below, we'll identify the unit of thought most commonly identified with each genre.

Epistolary Literature

An epistle is a personal letter. Romans, Jude, and Hebrews are all epistles. And in a personal letter, the quintessential unit of thought is a <u>sentence</u>. I don't mean that you can't find meaning in other units (clauses or paragraphs, for example). I just mean that

in epistles, sentences are usually the building blocks of the author's argument. A sentence typically conveys a single, complete thought.

For example, let's say we're outlining Paul's epistle to the Ephesians. Our first unit would be Ephesians 1:1-2 because that's the first complete sentence in the book.

> *"Paul, an apostle of Christ Jesus by the will of God, to the saints who are in Ephesus and who are faithful in Christ Jesus: Grace to you and peace from our Father and the Lord Jesus Christ."*

And our final unit would be Ephesians 6:24 because that's the last complete sentence in the book.

> *"Grace be with all those who love our Lord Jesus Christ with incorruptible love."*

Narrative Literature

Narrative literature tells a story. Judges, Matthew, and Acts are examples of narrative literature. And in a narrative, the quintessential unit of thought is a <u>scene</u>. I don't mean that you can't find meaning in other units. An author still constructs a narrative using sentences and paragraphs, but they're not the primary unit of thought like in a personal letter. In narratives, scenes are usually the building blocks of the author's argument.

When you're outlining narrative literature, think like a movie director. If you filmed this story, when would you cut away to a different time or location? Where does the plot "jump ahead" chronologically or geographically?

For example, let's say we're outlining the book of Acts. The author depicts the story of Pentecost in a single scene. The scene begins by establishing a new setting in Acts 2:1.

> *"When the day of Pentecost had come, they were all together in one place."*

And the "cut" is found in Acts 3:1, as the author introduces the next scene.

> *"Now Peter and John were going up to the temple at the ninth hour, the hour of prayer."*

Therefore, the entirety of chapter 2 is a single unit of thought. Of course, if we're studying Pentecost, we'd still want to dig deeper. But if we're outlining the whole book of Acts, Pentecost is a single literary unit.

Poetic Literature

Poetry can be a bit more complicated. Poets typically structure their work around some kind of literary device. For example, most Western literature is designed to rhyme. However, biblical poetry is different; it rarely rhymes, even in Hebrew. This is because most Ancient Near Eastern poetry was structured around another literary device: parallelism.

Parallelism is when an author arranges statements that compare or contrast with each other to produce meaningful, symbolic, or even ironic results. These statement-pairings are called <u>strophes</u>. And strophes are the quintessential unit of biblical poetry.

For example, Psalm 42:1 is a single strophe comprised of two parallel clauses. (I'll separate them with a forward slash to illustrate what I mean.)

> *"As the deer pants for water / so my soul pants for you, O God."*

Strophes don't necessarily involve word pictures or comparisons. Sometimes they're just two parallel thoughts paired together in a meaningful way. For example, consider Psalm 23:1.

> *"The Lord is my Shepherd / I shall not want."*

When outlining biblical poetry, a single strophe is a unit of thought.

Prophetic Literature

The writings of Isaiah, Ezekiel, and Jeremiah are examples of this genre. The prophets were essentially preachers, and their careers sometimes spanned many decades and multiple eras of Jewish history. We can often divide their written works into individual sermons. Now, we can (and should) outline each individual sermon on its own. But if we're outlining an entire prophetic book, each sermon is a quintessential unit of thought.

Sermons often begin by identifying their topic. For example, Isaiah 13 begins with the phrase, *"The oracle concerning Babylon which Isaiah the son of Amoz saw"* (13:1). This statement tells us what we're about to read.

Two chapters later, another sermon starts with *"The oracle concerning Moab…"* (15:1).

And another two chapters down the line, a third sermon begins, *"The oracle concerning Damascus…"* (17:1).

As I mentioned, we can (and should) dissect each of these sermons further. But most prophetic books are best outlined in terms of the sermons they contain. Due to the nature of prophetic ministry, sermons are the primary divisions inherent to that genre of literature.

Apocalyptic Literature

Have you ever listened to an old classic remixed by a cutting-edge DJ? It's surprising and intriguing because it could go anywhere! What was once an orchestral swell could become a pulsing bassline, a crooner's voice could become a mind-boggling beatbox, and so on. Apocalyptic literature does something similar.

The apocalyptic format is an interesting (and often confusing) mashup of other genres. And the key to grasping this format is understanding its references and allusions. You might enjoy the experience, but you won't truly "get" it unless you appreciate the other authors, genres, and theology that it's remixing.

For example, the Book of Revelation begins like an epistle.

> *"John to the seven churches that are in Asia: Grace to you and peace, from Him who is and who was and who is to come, and from the seven spirits which are before His throne, and from Jesus Christ, the faithful witness, the first-born of the dead, and the ruler of the kings of the earth"* (1:4).

However, within a few chapters, it shifts into a narrative.

> *"After these things I looked, and behold, a door standing open in heaven, and the first voice which I had heard, like the sound of a trumpet speaking with me, said, 'Come up here, and I will show you what must take place after these things.'"* (4:1)

Throughout the rest of the book, we also find several poetic sections like this one.

> *"And they sang a new song, saying, 'Worthy are You to take the book and break its seals; for You were slain, and purchased for God with your blood men from every tribe and tongue and people and nation"* (5:9).

And the entire book borrows style, imagery, and authority from the prophetic genre. John's conclusion especially highlights this aspect of the text.

> *"And he said to me, 'These words are faithful and true;' and the Lord, the God of the spirits of the prophets, sent His angel to show His bond-servants the things which must soon take place. 'And behold, I am coming quickly. Blessed is he who heeds the words of the prophecy of this book.'"* (22:6-7)

Scripture contains plenty of other genres and sub-genres. However, I've found that these five genres are the most recognizable. And when I start a new outline, I begin by identifying the genre and unit of that text. Now, let's look at the next important element of outlining.

Identifying Logical Movement

A conjunction is an essential part of speech. Conjunctions connect clauses, sentences, ideas, or thoughts by expressing the relationship between them. And when we're outlining a passage of Scripture, they allow us to identify logical movement. They serve as keywords, telegraphing the author's flow of thought, moving their argument forward clause by clause.

I want to call your attention to six types of conjunctions. The categories themselves aren't terribly important, but they serve to illustrate the purpose of conjunctions in the Bible. When you're outlining a passage of Scripture, be on the lookout for these keywords.

Coordinating Conjunctions show <u>equality</u> between two thoughts or clauses.

> Look for terms like *"and," "or," "nor," "for,"* and *"but."* Also, keep an eye out for conjunction pairings like *"neither… nor," "either… or,"* and *"both… and."*
>
> For example, Romans 2:2 begins with a coordinating conjunction. *"**And** we know that the judgment of God rightly falls upon those who practice such things."*

Adversative Conjunctions show <u>contrast</u>.

> Look for terms like *"but," "yet," "except," "however,"* and *"nevertheless."*

For example, Romans 3:21 begins with an adversative conjunction. *"**But** now apart from the law the righteousness of God has been manifested."*

Emphatic Conjunctions demonstrate <u>force</u>.

Look for terms like *"yea," "certainly," "verily," "truly,"* and *"in fact."*

For example, Romans 6:5 uses an emphatic conjunction to join two thoughts. *"For if we have become united with Him in the likeness of His death, **certainly** we shall also be in the likeness of his resurrection."*

Inferential Conjunctions show a <u>conclusion</u> or <u>relation</u> between ideas.

Look for terms like *"therefore," "so," "when," "wherefore,"* and *"for."*

For example, Romans 8:1 begins with an inferential conjunction. *"**Therefore** there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."*

Transitional Conjunctions demonstrate a <u>link</u> or <u>continuation</u> of thought.

Look for terms like *"and," "moreover,"* and *"then."*

For example, Romans 9:23 uses a transitional conjunction to continue an earlier thought. *"**And** He did so to make known the riches of His glory upon vessels of mercy."*

And **Subordinating Conjunctions** show a <u>dependent clause</u>.

Look for terms like *"when," "because," "if," "since,"* and *"although."*

For example, Romans 4:25 uses two subordinating conjunctions. *"He who was delivered over **because** of our transgressions, and was raised **because** of our justification."*

These categories are somewhat subjective. But I want you to start thinking about logical movement. Where is the author going? How do they get there? How are individual

ideas used to form a comprehensive argument? As we seek to answer these questions, it's helpful to understand the author's use of conjunctions.

We've addressed several foundational concepts. We've talked about the twin skills of summary and synthesis. We discussed the importance of genre in finding the unit of the text. And we've seen how conjunctions help us identify logical movement.

Now, let's put these concepts into practice. I want to conduct two exercises in Philippians 3. In the first exercise, we'll practice the skill of **Summary** – *condensing a lengthy, difficult, or complicated passage into simple statements.* And in the second exercise, we'll practice the skill of **Synthesis** – *combining multiple passages, sources, or ideas to form a single argument.*

I'd encourage you to attempt these on your own before reading my results. As I've already mentioned, practice makes perfect! Please read the instructions below and then follow them on your own. Once you've finished, jump back into the book and compare your results to mine.

Summary Exercise

Text

Philippians 3

Instructions

1. Divide the chapter into sentences.
2. For each sentence, note that unit's reference on a new line.
3. Next to each reference, summarize the content of that sentence.
4. Once complete, compare the results below.

Results

Step 1 asked us to divide the chapter into sentences. Why sentences? Because Philippians is an epistle, and the quintessential unit of epistolary literature is a sentence. Therefore, we can identify our units by finding every period in Philippians 3. Punctuation placement varies slightly depending on which translation of the Bible you're using. And that's okay. Most modern translations will be very similar to each other. (It's also common for one translation to use a semicolon where another uses a period. If you'd prefer, you can also treat semicolons like periods: as the end of a unit.)

Step 2 asked us to note the reference for each unit on a new line. You may have noticed that some sentences begin or end right in the middle of a verse. In such cases, you can use "abc" notation to be more specific. For example, "3:1a" refers to the *first half* of the *first verse* of the *third chapter*, and "3:1b" refers to the *second half* of the verse. Once you've completed Step 2, you have the beginnings of an outline. Mine looked like this:

(3:1a) _____

(3:1b) _____

(3:2-4a) _____

(3:4b-6) _____

(3:7) _____

(3:8-11) _____

(3:12) _____

(3:13-14) _____

(3:15-16) _____

(3:17) _____

(3:18-19) _____

(3:20-21) _____

Step 3 asked us to summarize the content of each unit. This is the hard part. For each sentence-unit we've identified, we need to reduce the overall statement to its simplest form. Let's take the first few lines together.

Our first unit is Philippians 3:1a, which says, *"Finally, my brethren, rejoice in the Lord."* This statement is already quite short. We can distill it down to something like, "Rejoice in the Lord." We'll put that down as our first summary.

(3:1a) _Rejoice in the Lord_____

Our second unit is Philippians 3:1b, which says, *"To write the same things again is no trouble to me, and it is a safeguard for you."* This one is a bit more complicated, and there are probably many ways we could summarize it. But I came up with this: "Repetition is a safeguard." Do you see how that statement captures what Paul is getting at in this unit? We'll put that down as our second summary.

(3:1a) _Rejoice in the Lord_____

(3:1b) _Repetition is a safeguard_____

Our third unit is Philippians 3:2-4a, which is noticeably longer. *"Beware of the dogs, beware of evil workers, beware of the false circumcision; for we are the true circumcision, who worship in the Spirit of God and glory in Christ Jesus and put no confidence in the flesh, although I myself might have confidence even in the flesh."*

What do we do with this? We need to reduce it somehow. But what is "the false circumcision?" And what does Paul mean by "the flesh?"

To understand these things, we'll eventually have to study them in-depth. However, we don't need to understand everything a verse is saying to outline it initially. (In fact, outlining the passage will provide vital context for understanding these kinds of details

in light of Paul's whole argument. Therefore, we should be outlining before finalizing our interpretation of these verses.) For now, we can distill this overall statement into a simplified summary.

By stripping away descriptive and repetitive clauses, I arrived at this summary: "Beware the false circumcision; for we put no confidence in the flesh."

Do you see how that statement captures what Paul is getting at in this unit? Although we haven't studied "the false circumcision" or "the flesh," we still grasp Paul's main statements. And we've preserved the inferential conjunction *"for"* in the middle of the sentence. We're not reinventing the wheel or even interpreting Paul's language; we're just reflecting what we find in the text.

We'll put that down as our third summary. After that, I continued summarizing each unit until I completed the entire chapter. Here's what I got.

(3:1a) Rejoice in the Lord

(3:1b) Repetition is a safeguard

(3:2-4a) Beware the false circumcision; for we put no confidence in the flesh

(3:4b-6) In the past, Paul put his confidence in the flesh through the law

(3:7) But Paul has counted all that as loss

(3:8-11) Now, Paul puts his confidence in Christ through faith

(3:12) Paul presses on for the Christian purpose

(3:13-14) Paul presses on for the upward call

(3:15-16) Keep on living by this standard

(3:17) Imitate examples of this perseverance

(3:18-19) Because many are enemies of the gospel

(3:20-21) But we are citizens of heaven

Step 4 asked us to compare our results. How did you divide and summarize this chapter? How closely did it align with my results above? Don't be discouraged if they were different. There's no one right way to outline a passage. The Scriptures themselves are inspired, but our summaries are not. We're merely engaging with the text, trying to figure out what Paul's saying.

However, I do hope that my summaries were helpful. In this exercise, I've tried to demonstrate how to distill each statement down to its core ideas. Now, let's take our results into the next exercise.

Synthesis Exercise

Text

Philippians 3

Instructions

Starting with your results from the last exercise:

1. Group your summaries into high-level movements.
2. For each group you've identified, create a header with a title summarizing its content.
3. If possible, identify groups of groups within the argument flow.

Results

Step 1 asked us to group our summaries into high-level movements. This exercise is even more subjective than the last one, and different people will pick up on different movements. I'll show you how I completed this assignment below, but don't be concerned if it looks a bit different than yours.

When I was creating my example, I noticed a few keywords throughout the chapter. These keywords seemed to represent themes that Paul wanted to focus on throughout his argument. The first keyword was *"rejoice,"* which seemed to feature most prominently in verses 1-2. Because I had read Philippians repeatedly, I knew that joy was a running theme throughout the entire epistle.

(3:1a) **Rejoice** in the Lord

(3:1b) Repetition is a safeguard

The second keyword word was *"confidence."* I realized that I had used this word repeatedly in my unit summaries. It seemed mostly concentrated in verses 2-11, where Paul contrasts confidence in the flesh with confidence in Christ.

(3:2-4a) Beware the false circumcision; for we put no **confidence** in the flesh

(3:4b-6) In the past, Paul put his **confidence** in the flesh through the law

(3:7) But Paul has counted all that as loss

(3:8-11) Now, Paul puts his **confidence** in Christ through faith

And the third keyword was *"perseverance."* In verses 12-21, several of my unit summaries mentioned "pressing on," "keeping on," and "perseverance." That kind of repetitive, thematic use of language told me that Paul wanted to focus on a particular theme in that section.

(3:12) Paul **presses on** for the Christian purpose

(3:13-14) Paul **presses on** for the upward call

(3:15-16) **Keep on** living by this standard

(3:17) Imitate examples of this **perseverance**

(3:18-19) Because many are enemies of the gospel

(3:20-21) But we are citizens of heaven

Step 2 asked us to title each movement we identified. I stuck with something simple. Using the themes I identified in the previous step, I came up with three headers that express the content of those movements.

(3:1) Joy in the Lord

(3:1a) Rejoice in the Lord

(3:1b) Repetition is a safeguard

(3:2-11) Confidence in the Lord

(3:2-4a) Beware the false circumcision; for we put no confidence in the flesh

(3:4b-6) In the past, Paul put his confidence in the flesh through the law

(3:7) But Paul has counted all that as loss

(3:8-11) Now, Paul puts his confidence in Christ through faith

(3:12-21) Perseverance in the Lord

(3:12) Paul presses on for the Christian purpose

(3:13-14) Paul presses on for the upward call

(3:15-16) Keep on living by this standard

(3:17) Imitate examples of this perseverance

(3:18-19) Because many are enemies of the gospel

(3:20-21) But we are citizens of heaven

Step 3 asked us to identify "groups of groups" within the argument flow. Our goal is to reflect the movements apparent in the text. And this step is intended to furnish our outline with additional detail, adding more headers if needed. This adjustment is not always possible – or needed. But in this case, my third and final group seemed a bit longer than the others. Although I had identified the theme of "Perseverance in the

Lord," it contained six sentence units with no further detail noted in my outline. It seemed like I could probably divide that group into sub-arguments.

I essentially went back to Step 1 but limited my scope to verses 12-21. What sub-themes could I identify here? Well, I noticed that my first two summaries were *indicative statements*. Paul was presenting himself as an example of perseverance.

(3:12) **Paul presses on** for the Christian purpose

(3:13-14) **Paul presses on** for the upward call

I saw that my next two summaries were *imperative statements* (commands). Paul shifted from describing himself to instructing his audience.

(3:15-16) **Keep on living** by this standard

(3:17) **Imitate** examples of this perseverance

And I saw that my final two summaries were *explanatory statements*. I noticed that both sentence-units (18-19 and 20-21) began with the word "for" – an inferential conjunction. And my summary conveyed the implied contrast between enemies of the gospel and citizens of heaven, so I knew these two units were a pair.

(3:18-19) **Because** many are enemies of the gospel

(3:20-21) **But** we are citizens of heaven

After making these observations, I divided that third movement into three sub-points. This adjustment more accurately traced Paul's argument in Philippians 3, and helped me understand the text better. That final section ended up looking like this.

(3:12-21) Perseverance in the Lord

(3:12-14) Example

(3:12) Paul presses on for the Christian purpose

(3:13-14) Paul presses on for the upward call

(3:15-17) Instruction

(3:15-16) Keep on living by this standard

(3:17) Imitate examples of this perseverance

(3:18-21) Reasoning

(3:18-19) Because many are enemies of the gospel

(3:20-21) But we are citizens of heaven

Exercise Results

By exercising these two skills – summary and synthesis – we've outlined Philippians 3. We began by dividing the chapter into its units (sentences) and summarizing the content of each unit. Then, we grouped those units into high-level movements and titled them appropriately. And we continued to alternately group and summarize until arriving at a satisfactory level of detail. That's the process of outlining!

Your outline will look different from mine. If I sound like a broken record, it's because I want to emphasize just how personal the process of outlining can be. When we outline Scripture, we are not generating something authoritative. We're simply notating our observations about the author's argument flow. Outlines are personal tools, self-drawn maps of the literary and grammatical context of a passage. The process of generating one is just as valuable as having a finished one.

As I worked through this exercise, my outline ended up looking like this:

(3:1) Joy in the Lord

(3:1a) Rejoice in the Lord

(3:1b) Repetition is a safeguard

(3:2-11) Confidence in the Lord

(3:2-4a) Beware the false circumcision; for we put no confidence in the flesh

(3:4b-6) In the past, Paul put his confidence in the flesh through the law

(3:7) But Paul has counted all that as loss

(3:8-11) Now, Paul puts his confidence in Christ through faith.

(3:12-21) Perseverance in the Lord

(3:12-14) Example

(3:12) Paul presses on for the Christian purpose

(3:13-14) Paul presses on for the upward call

(3:15-17) Instruction

(3:15-16) Keep on living by this standard

(3:17) Imitate examples of this perseverance

(3:18-21) Reasoning

(3:18-19) Because many are enemies of the gospel

(3:20-21) But we are citizens of heaven

A Practical Technique for Outlining

To outline an entire book of the Bible, we follow the same process detailed above. But instead of focusing on a single chapter, we widen our scope to the whole book. Now that you're familiar with this process, I want to propose a practical technique for outlining books of the Bible. I'll list the steps and explain them below.

1. Read the book repetitively.
2. Identify major divisions.
3. Break the text down into units.
4. Summarize each unit.
5. Group the units by commonality.
6. Repeat 4 and 5 until no longer possible.

I want to stress the importance of Step 1. Repetitive reading is an integral part of engaging the text. I usually read a book two or three times before outlining it. And as I read, I note potential movements, themes, and sub-topics. These notes accumulate across multiple readings so that I already have a pretty good idea of what the author's getting at by the time I start outlining.

Step 2 is especially essential when outlining longer books. It can be challenging to analyze an entire body of work as a single entity, so I've found myself identifying major divisions first. Then I can tackle each in order. To identify these high-level sections, I look for big moments. These might be major plot points like David's sin with Bathsheba (2 Samuel 11). It could be a shift in genre, like the unexpected and unrepeated use of narrative in Amos 7:10. Maybe there's a shift in perspective, like the section of Daniel written by Nebuchadnezzar (Daniel 4). Or perhaps there are theological crescendos like Paul's climactic "therefore" in Romans 8:1. Once I've identified these big moments, I can divide the book into high-level movements and outline each individually. This approach makes it much easier to outline an entire book.

Steps 3 through 6 follow the same process as our earlier exercises. Using this technique, we can study whole books with an organized approach. Outlining empowers us to apply a literal, historical, grammatical hermeneutic at the macro-level, strengthening our exegetical efforts at the micro-level.

In this sense, outlining should be considered an essential part of exegesis. When we take the time to digest the high-level argument of the text, we will inevitably reap richer results from our study of any one passage within that text. I strongly encourage you to practice these skills often. You'll get better at outlining over time, and as you do, I believe you'll find the exercise more and more valuable.

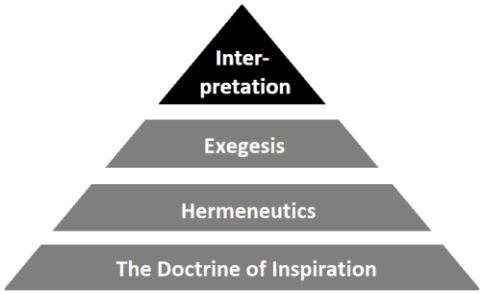
Scripture References

- Pick an entire book of the Bible to outline.
    - For more accessible books, try Habakkuk, Jude, or 3 John.
    - For intermediate books, try Jonah, Romans, or 1 Peter.
    - For more challenging books, try Job, James, or 1 John.

Discussion Questions

- Which part of the outlining process did you find most challenging? Why?
- Using a study Bible or the internet, find at least two other outlines of the same book. How does your outline differ? Which do you prefer, and why?
- What will you do differently the next time you outline a book of the Bible?

7. Using Exegetical Tools



When you're asking questions about a passage, outlining doesn't give you all the answers. Maybe you need to research a book's historical context. Perhaps you're looking for biographical information about the author or a particular character. In such cases, you'll almost always need to turn to external resources.

As Americans in the 21st Century, we're incredibly blessed. Books are more accessible and less expensive than they've ever been. The internet has made millions of texts available for little or no cost. Compared to many of our brethren overseas and in past ages, we have access to an unprecedented breadth of Christian literature. We must not fail to take advantage of this! However, this immense blessing can create issues of its own.

The sheer volume of literature available to us can quickly become overwhelming. There are thousands of potential resources vying to answer any question you might have. Understanding the various categories and uses of these tools can sometimes feel like insider information, reserved for the "professionals." How do you know which one to use? What's the right tool for the job? When do you turn to a commentary? And how do you decide whether to accept or reject an author's interpretation?

In this chapter, I hope to clarify these issues for you.

We'll start by reviewing some common categories of exegetical tools. I'll recommend some choice resources to get you started, many of which are free or widely accessible. Then, we'll talk about how to use these resources appropriately and independently. And finally, we'll walk through some examples out of Philippians 3.

Types of Tools

The first thing to know is that there are different types of biblical resources. The universe of biblical studies is immense and ever-expanding. New, cutting-edge reference works release with enough frequency that it can be tough to keep up. However, in this book, I'll focus on tried-and-true resources, and there are two reasons why.

First, I like to keep the focus off the resources and on the Scriptures. Our ability to study the Bible is not dependent on owning the latest, greatest lexicon or commentary set. If you're a study nerd like me, I don't mean to discourage you from checking out the latest releases. But let's remember that Christians have been faithfully studying God's Word for thousands of years. And many of our forefathers had comparatively limited access to reference and commentary literature. For this reason, I'll be recommending established and time-tested tools.

Second, many of these widely accepted tools are cheaper and more accessible. Most of us do not have access to seminary libraries or subscribe to academic journals. We won't be dropping $200 for a lexicon or $1,000 for a commentary set. As valuable and enriching as many of those resources may be, they are not accessible for most Christians. For this reason, I like to recommend accessible resources that are free or reasonably priced.

With those caveats out of the way, let's look at some high-level categories of exegetical tools.

Study Bibles

Study Bibles are simply Bibles that contain a limited amount of commentary to aid the reader in understanding. A Study Bible usually includes detailed introductory material for each book. I recommend the *ESV Study Bible* and *The Open Bible*.

If you're trying to answer a question about a whole book, a study Bible is a great place to get a quick, concise answer. Who was the author? When did they live? What were they addressing? Study Bibles will address these topics in their introductory material. These brief articles are typically easy to consume and designed for daily study.

Commentaries

A commentary is an author's interpretation of a biblical text, following the consecutive order of the text. There is a great deal of variation among commentaries. Some are comprehensive, covering the entire canon of Scripture (like *Matthew Henry's Commentary on the Whole Bible*). Others focus on a specific facet of the Scriptures (like Carson and Beale's *Commentary on the New Testament Use of the Old Testament*). Some sets are written by multiple authors, usually a collection of specialists in various books or genres. Others reflect a single author's view on an entire corpus, testament, or the whole Bible.

Not all commentaries are written for the same audience or used in the same ways. I generally group commentaries into three broad sub-categories.

Devotional Commentaries

Devotional commentaries aim at straightforward exposition and application. They are not unlike long-form sermons and typically engage a more general audience. The author(s) should still address major interpretive issues and engage with linguistic aspects of the text. But they may not delve into the full reasoning behind their exegetical decisions. I recommend *Matthew Henry's Commentary on the Whole Bible* and *The NIV Application Commentary* series.

Are you struggling to conceptualize how a passage could apply to us today? Are you looking for a pithy quote that perfectly encapsulates the meaning of a passage? A devotional commentary is a great place to go for these sorts of needs.

Exegetical Commentaries

Exegetical commentaries aim at explanation and exploration. They usually assume a certain level of Greek and/or Hebrew proficiency and are therefore written for a more academic audience. Exegetical commentaries should discuss major interpretive issues and address multiple viewpoints where applicable. I recommend *The New International Commentary* series and *The Word Biblical Commentary* series.

Are you trying to understand the merits and flaws of various interpretations of a text? Do you require some detailed context on a particular Greek or Hebrew word? An exegetical commentary will help you answer these sorts of questions.

Hybrid Commentaries

Hybrid commentaries are a mix of the two categories mentioned above. They're more academic and expositional than a devotional commentary but more straightforward

and applicational than an exegetical commentary. I recommend *The Expositor's Bible Commentary* and *The Tyndale Old and New Testament Commentaries*.

Looking for a quick "health check" on your interpretation of a passage? Want to make sure you're not completely off the deep end? While you'll never find a single commentary that addresses every possible area, hybrid commentaries are great go-to resources. Use them to make sure you're covering your bases, not forgetting some crucial element of the text you may have overlooked.

These three types of commentaries all play their own role in a well-balanced approach to the text. While it can be expensive and time-consuming to own these resources, many are free or cheap online. In Appendix B, I've listed the current links to several free commentaries.

Bible Dictionaries

A Bible dictionary is a collection of articles elaborating on names, places, texts, and topics found in the Bible. It's usually sorted alphabetically, like an encyclopedia. Good Bible dictionaries include comprehensive bibliographies for each entry, making them an excellent entry point for any topical study. Bible dictionaries usually aren't the work of a single author. I recommend *The Holman Illustrated Bible Dictionary* and *The Anchor Yale Bible Dictionary*.

Are you studying a specific person, place, or thing in Scripture? Do you need to quickly collect a wide swath of biographical material about a Bible character? Are you looking for a list of other books to read on a particular subject? A Bible dictionary is the perfect place to start your search.

Concordances

A concordance is a reference work that lists the usages of a specific word throughout the whole Bible. These are useful when studying a term or concept as it develops throughout Scripture. Concordances are organized alphabetically. I recommend *Strong's Exhaustive Concordance of the Bible* and *Young's Analytical Concordance to the Bible*.

Are you studying a specific concept, phrase, or term in Scripture? Do you need to collect a list of passages that use a particular word? A Concordance will help you get those answers quickly.

Lexicons

A lexicon is a dictionary of terms in a biblical language like Greek, Hebrew, or Aramaic. Lexicons are organized alphabetically – but in the alphabet of their target language. (For example, a Greek lexicon will begin with *Alpha* and end with *Omega*.) A good lexicon should list multiple potential definitions for a given word based on context, usage, or even time period. "Abridged" or "pocket" lexicons usually provide a few simple "glosses" of Greek or Hebrew words.

For Greek, I recommend *Abbott-Smith's Manual Greek Lexicon of the New Testament*, and for Hebrew, I recommend *The Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew-English Lexicon of the Old Testament*. Some expensive but highly recommended alternatives are the lengthily titled *A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature* (commonly referred to as BDAG) and *A Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament* (commonly referred to as *HALOT*).

A word about lexicons: use them with caution. If you don't already know the ins and outs of Greek or Hebrew grammar, never build an interpretation upon the information you find in a lexicon. (In fact, you probably shouldn't be doing that even if you do

know Greek or Hebrew!) This might like a strange thing to say, so let me illustrate this point with a brief story.

Several years ago, an acquaintance of mine came to a startling realization about the Greek word *baptizo* (from which we derive the English word "baptize"). You see, his lexicon listed several different definitions for *baptizo*. The first was pretty straightforward: *"to immerse in liquid."* But the fourth or fifth definition was more puzzling: *"to pickle."*

(Now, it should be obvious that the New Testament isn't referring to pickling people. *Baptizo* simply carried the connotation of immersing something in liquid. And at some point in the ancient world, someone used this term to describe the process of preserving food in brine.)

Based on this word study, he excitedly proclaimed that a believer's baptism serves as a kind of spiritual preservative. Baptism, he claimed, guards us against decay, extends our spiritual shelf life, and makes us "salty." Funny, but wrong! That's an example of how *not* to use a lexicon. Any Greek professor worth their salt (pun intended) will repeat this simple mantra time and again: "context, context, context." Context is king. Just because a word *can* mean something doesn't mean it *does* mean that thing every time it appears.

Cross Referencing Tools

This category is an important one. You may find these resources referred to as "harmonies," "synopses," or "cross-references." Cross-referencing tools connect passages of Scripture to other passages of Scripture. They are typically arranged in the same order as your Bible. When you flip to a particular book, chapter, and verse, you will find a list of other verses that complement, explain, or clarify the one you're

looking up. I recommend *The Treasury of Scripture Knowledge* and *The Thompson Chain Reference Bible* (a Bible that integrates extensive cross-references).

Does an author allude to previously written Scripture? Are you trying to answer the question, "What other passages of Scripture clarify and/or illustrate this text?" Turn to a cross-referencing tool to get started.

Other Types of Tools

There are many other categories of resources, too. From *Systematic Theologies* to *Historical Surveys*, *Grammars* to *Bible Atlases*, we could spend many chapters unpacking all the types of literature in the world of biblical studies. However, for our purposes, the categories I've highlighted above are the most important.

I usually access these tools in three ways: *hard copy, digital, or internet archive.* The first two formats typically require a purchase. The third option is increasingly viable with popular sites like **Archive.org** and **Google Books**. Learn how to build a well-structured query in Google, and you can find almost anything.

Using Tools

Now, understanding the categories of tools is only the first step. How do we actually use these tools? To use extrabiblical study resources effectively, you must be intentional with them. There are three areas where intentionality is crucial.

First, you must possess **normal reading comprehension**. It might seem like this should go without saying, but trust me – it doesn't. When I began studying the Bible in earnest, I had to refresh my knowledge of basic English grammar. What's the difference

between the object and subject of a sentence? What's a preposition? I had to work on basic reading skills before I could accurately engage the Bible and exegetical tools.

Second, you must practice **organized note-taking**. Keep a list of questions you're trying to resolve, including (but not limited to) our "Ask the Text" questions. And keep a list of your answers – even answers that may disagree with each other. Keep a list of observations you make while reading or outlining. I'd also encourage you to keep a list of instinctual, intuitive interpretations of a passage, even if they might prove wrong. Sometimes writing them down exposes cognitive biases you may not have otherwise recognized. And getting them down on paper keeps them out of your head until you've finished the work of exegesis.

There are many different methods of note-taking. Maybe you write in the margins of your Bible. Maybe you use Sticky Notes or notepads. You might go the digital route with Microsoft Word, Kindle Notes, or Logos Bible Software. I highly recommend the ESV Scripture Journals, which provide plenty of writing space for outlines and observations. Writing things down helps keep you objective. It doesn't matter where you store your notes – anywhere but your head!

And third, to use exegetical tools rightly, you must adopt **interpretive freedom**. Your goal should never be to "fall in line" with someone else's interpretation. When you read commentaries, you should use their conclusions to help you form your own.

Now, I do not mean that you should remove the doctrinal boundaries of orthodoxy when you're studying a text. You don't need to wipe off the theological slate of your mind every time you approach a text. But at the end of the day, if we believe that the Bible is God's truth, then it should hold up under scrutiny. Don't ever adopt an interpretation purely because the professionals say so. The Scriptures not only *can* make sense to you, they *must* make sense to you.

When extrabiblical tools enter the picture, it's crucial to practice intentionality in these three areas. We use these resources appropriately when we approach them with solid reading comprehension, organized note-taking, and interpretive freedom.

Exegetical Examples

Let's look at a few examples from the passage we outlined last chapter, Philippians 3. Say we're asking two initial questions about the author:

- When did they write this?
- Where did they live?

Where would we go to find this information? One place might be a trustworthy Study Bible. Like most Study Bibles, *The Open Bible* includes a wealth of useful introductory material before each book. And sure enough, the introduction to Philippians speaks to the questions of "when?" and "where?" quite openly.

> *"Silas, Timothy, Luke, and Paul first came to Philippi in* ***A.D. 51, eleven years before Paul wrote this letter****. Philippians 1:13 and 4:22 suggest that* ***it was written from Rome****, although some commentators argue for Caesarea or Ephesus. Paul's life was at stake, and he was evidently awaiting the verdict of the Imperial Court (2:20-26)."* (emphasis mine)

So *The Open Bible* suggests that Paul wrote his letter to the Philippians from Rome in 62 A.D. Let's look at another reliable resource to compare. In the *ESV Study Bible*'s introduction to Philippians, we find this helpful section:

> *"Scholars have debated Paul's location when he wrote Philippians. Caesarea, Ephesus, and Rome have been the three most commonly proposed locations. Paul was in fact imprisoned in the 'praetorium' of Herod the Great in Caesarea (Acts*

> *23:35; cf. ESV footnote on Phil 1:13) around A.D. 60. But his statements to the Philippians about his possibly imminent death (e.g., 1:20) would be puzzling if coming from Caesarea, since he would have been able to request a trial in Rome, as in fact he did. Ephesus was close enough to Philippi for Paul to receive regular news from there, but there is no mention of his ever being imprisoned in Ephesus. On balance,* ***it seems most likely that the letter was written from Rome, c. A.D. 62.*** *This also fits most naturally with the mention of the praetorium and 'Caesar's household' (1:13 and 4:22)."* (emphasis mine)

These two different resources are closely aligned. If we desired, we could compare several other resources to validate. But even with two, we have a reasonable ability to answer our initial questions.

- **When did they write this?** *Paul wrote his letter to the Philippians in roughly 62 A.D., around eleven years after visiting Philippi and planting the Christian church there.*
- **Where did they live?** *Although Paul was from Damascus, he most likely wrote this letter from Rome while in prison awaiting trial.*

So why is this information relevant?

Well, it's interesting to note that Paul has already known his audience for a long time. And it's helpful to remember that he's writing from prison. These facts contextualize his statements in Philippians 3:12-21 (the section we entitled "Perseverance in the Lord" in our outline). In 3:17, when Paul urges his audience to *"join in following my example"* of perseverance, we know what example he means. He has spent more than a decade modeling patient, joyful sacrifice. And he does so now from prison. That kind of longsuffering for the sake of the gospel is what Paul means by "my example." Knowing the time and location of writing clues us into Paul's authorial intent. And that, in turn, helps us more accurately apply this truth to ourselves.

Let's consider another example.

When studying the Bible, I find that *comparing different translations* helps me identify interesting, important, or challenging words. There's not always a noticeable difference between translations, but when there is one, it's probably worth conducting a brief word study. Let's look at the difference between two reliable translations of Philippians 3:15a.

New American Standard Version	English Standard Version
*"Let us therefore, as many as are **perfect**, have this attitude…"*	*"Let those of us who are **mature** think this way…"*

The words "perfect" and "mature" are pretty different from each other! So why have two relatively similar versions of the Bible used them both to translate the same idea? And what does that fact tell us about the meaning of this passage? To answer such questions, we can turn to a few types of resources. First, let's look at a commentary. *A Commentary Critical and Explanatory on the Whole Bible* by Jamieson, Fausset, and Brown is a well-known resource available for free online. Here's what it says for Philippians 3:15.

> *"'As many of us then, as are perfect,' that is, full grown (no longer 'babes') in the Christian life (Php 3:3, 'worshipping God in the Spirit, and having no confidence in the flesh'), 1 Co 2:6, fully established in the things of God. Here, by 'perfect' he means one fully fit for running [BENGEL]; knowing and complying with the laws of the course (2 Ti 2:5). Though 'perfect' in this sense, he was not yet 'made perfect' (Greek) in the sense intended in Php 3:12, namely, 'crowned with complete victory,' and having attained absolute perfection."*

Although written in a halting, referential style, this commentary is helpful. It gives us a few cross-references and helps us understand the idea in this passage. When Paul says

"perfect," he's not referring to morally flawless people. He's using the term subjectively. He's referring to people who are grown up in their faith, who are fit to run the race. This idea sounds very close to the ESV's way of translating the word as "mature," doesn't it?

Another essential point of reference here is the often-overlooked footnotes in the New American Standard Bible. In cases where an alternate wording is reasonable, the footnotes will usually make a note of it. And so it is here. When you read Philippians 3:15, you'll notice a tiny footnote next to the word "perfect," like this.

> *"Let us therefore, as many as are [1]perfect…"*

When you follow the footnote into the margins, there is a brief, one-word explanation:

> [1] *Mature*

In other words, the NASB recognizes the difficulty of translating this word. While they've chosen "perfect" for the main text, "mature" is a reasonable alternative translation. We don't need to be thrown off by this term. By comparing a commentary and a footnote, we can quickly grasp what Paul intended with this verse.

So why is this information relevant?

By understanding Paul's intention, we avoid the potential misinterpretation that Christians can ever achieve moral perfection. Although some have cited this verse when making such claims, that's not the main idea in this passage. On the contrary, this phrase highlights the Apostle Paul's humility and transparency. After more than a decade of discipleship, he's still open with his friends: "I'm mature, but I'm not there yet. I have no reason to boast in anything except in Jesus Christ, my Lord."

And let's consider one more example.

Let's say we're studying Philippians 3:20, which says, *"For our citizenship is in heaven, from which also we eagerly wait for a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ."* Where do we go to answer the question "what other passages of Scripture clarify and/or illustrate this text?"

If we turn to *The Treasury of Scripture Knowledge*, we'll find this entry for Philippians 3:20:

> *(20)* ***our.*** *ch. 1:18–21. Ps. 16:11, 17:15; 73:24–26. Pr. 15:24. Mat. 6:19–21; 19:21. Lu. 12:21, 32–34; 14:14. 2 Co. 4:18; 5:1, 8. Ep. 2:6, 19. Col. 1:5; 3:1–3. He. 10:34, 35. 1 Pe. 1:3, 4.* ***citizenship.*** *Gr. Is. 26:1, 2. Ga. 4:26. Ep. 2:19. He. 12:22. Re. 21:10–27.* ***from.*** *Ac. 1:11. 1 Th. 4:16. 2 Th. 1:7, 8. Re. 1:7.* ***we wait.*** *ch. 1:10. 1 Co. 1:7. 1 Th. 1:10. 2 Ti. 4:8. Tit. 2:13. He. 9:28. 2 Pe. 3:12–14.*

This is a pretty dense wall of references, isn't it? But it gives us a lot to go on. Notice how the verse is divided into sections by keyword. As we're studying, we can explore all these cross-references and see how they relate to the main passage. Let's say we're trying to understand Paul's reference to "citizenship in heaven." What does that mean? What other passages of Scripture clarify this for us?

The cross-reference to Ephesians 2 is especially helpful. Verses 18-20 say this, *"For through Him we both have access in one Spirit to the Father. So then you are no longer strangers and aliens, but you are fellow citizens with the saints, and are of God's household, having been built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Christ Jesus Himself being the cornerstone."*

Our citizenship in heaven is "through" Jesus Christ. Our inclusion into God's kingdom is because we are in Him; our relationship to Jesus is our passport, the documentation of our spiritual citizenship. And that citizenship binds us

together as Christians. In this sense, earthly citizenship is different than the heavenly citizenship Paul's talking about here. We are united not by social or ethnic similarity but by our mutual relationship to Jesus Christ. Paul refers to this whole collective group as "God's household." As members of this household, the foundation of our fellowship is that which God revealed to "the apostles and prophets" – the Bible. And the cornerstone that brings this all into alignment is Christ Jesus Himself.

So, back in Philippians, when Paul wrote that *"our citizenship is in heaven, from which we also eagerly wait for a Savior, the Lord Jesus Christ,"* he's trying to direct our attention to two things: where we truly belong (heaven), and why we truly belong there (Jesus).

Using cross-reference tools to explain Scripture with other Scripture is one of the most powerful ways to dig into a concept or phrase. I encourage you to make this a regular part of your Bible study. You'll begin to see the development of theological themes across the entire canon of Scripture.

Summary

As we take a curious, intellectually honest approach to the Scriptures, we can utilize interpretive tools to help us answer critical questions. We ought not to lean upon them too much, essentially outsourcing the hard work of exegesis. We want to interpret the Scripture confidently for ourselves. But we don't want to study in a vacuum, either. We ought to recognize the efforts of those who have gone before us and use their conclusions to help us form our own.

We want to be like the Christians in ancient Berea, of whom Paul said in Acts 17:11, *"Now these were more noble-minded than those in Thessalonica, for they received*

the word with great eagerness, examining the Scriptures daily to see whether these things were so." In other words, we want to accept teachings that will genuinely benefit us. But we strive to be discerning. We strive to accept these teachings not because someone impressive has delivered them or because others accept them, but because they genuinely make sense.

I hope this chapter has encouraged you to find and utilize time-tested resources in your daily Bible study. In Appendix B, I will provide a brief bibliography of reliable tools. Wherever possible, I will provide links to free versions available online.

Discussion Questions

- What exegetical tools have you found helpful in your own Bible study?
- What new resources did you learn about in this chapter that you'd like to use?
- Look at the "Ask the Text" questions from chapter 4. For each subordinate question, what types of resources could you potentially use to find the answer?

8. Conclusion

What have we learned in this book?

We began with some interpretive concepts.

We've seen how foundational the doctrine of inspiration is to the entire practice of studying our Bibles. Therefore, we affirm the view of Christians throughout history: Verbal Plenary Inspiration, meaning that the precise wording of Scripture is God-breathed and thus bears God's authority. In other words, the Bible is both the Word of God and the words of God.

Hermeneutics (the principles used to determine the meaning of a text) are built upon the doctrine of inspiration. 2 Peter 1:19-21 tells us that the way we get meaning out of the text is dependent on the way God put meaning into the text. Therefore, we ascribe to a Literal Historical Grammatical Hermeneutic, a commonsense reading, taking into account the historical setting and linguistic choices of the author to determine his originally intended meaning.

And sound exegesis (the process used to determine the meaning of a text) is based upon this Literal Historical Grammatical Hermeneutic. Getting to authorial intent takes hard work! But the work of exegesis is worth it; we reap invaluable benefits when we seek to grasp the context and original meaning of every passage we study.

In addition to these interpretive concepts, we've also learned some practical skills.

We learned how to ask the text questions. What did this text mean to the human author? What does this text teach me about God? How should this text

contribute to my theology? And how does this text apply to me? We should bring these essential questions to the table when we study, seeking to understand the meaning, significance, and application of every text. But how do we actually answer them?

Well, we started with outlining. Outlining is essential because it develops authorial intent, discovers the passage's structure, and determines sections for concentrated study. As we notate the structures, themes, and argument flow of a book of the Bible, we gain valuable literary and grammatical context to help us answer our questions about the text.

We also learned how to utilize exegetical tools. With solid reading comprehension, organized note-taking, and interpretive freedom, we can use others' conclusions to help us form our own. Study Bibles, commentaries, Bible dictionaries, lexicons, concordances, and other reliable tools can provide valuable context to help us answer our questions about the text and double-check our interpretive instincts.

Speaking of resources, I hope this book proves helpful for you.

As I stated in the introduction, my goal is to foster confidence. These things matter, not only for pastors and "professionals," but for ordinary Christians. These things matter because they were revealed to you, because wolves don't go after shepherds, and because you're in the ministry.

That being said, our confidence is not found in ourselves as able interpreters, but in God's Word as clear and understandable. Go forth and dive into the riches of the Scriptures. Explore ancient truths. Uncover new treasures. And remember: *"The grass withers, the flower fades, but the word of our God stands forever"* (Isaiah 40:8).

Appendix A: "Ask the Text" Questions

What did this text mean to the human author?

Who were they?

When did they write this?

Where did they live?

What were they addressing?

What was in *their* Bible?

What does this text teach me about God?

What is God doing or saying in this text?

Why is God doing or saying it?

How is God doing or saying it?

Which of God's attributes are on display in this text?

How should this text contribute to my theology?

How does this text advance the metanarrative of Scripture?

How does this text point to Christ?

What other passages of Scripture clarify and/or illustrate this text?

What areas of systematic theology relate to this text?

How does this truth apply to me?

What is my relationship to the human author?

What is my relationship to the orginal audience?

What are the differences between my world and their world?

Is my relationship to God different than theirs?

Appendix B: Recommended Resources

Topical Reading

Can I Trust the Bible? by R.C. Sproul (**print**) (**ligonier.org**)

The Inspiration and Authority of the Bible by B.B. Warfield (**print**) (**monergism.org**)

How to Read the Bible for All Its Worth by Gordon Fee and Douglas Stuart (**print**) (**Logos**)

The Hermeneutics of the Biblical Writers by Abner Chou (**print**) (**Logos**)

Reading the Bible Supernaturally by John Piper (**print**) (**desiringgod.org**)

Toward an Exegetical Theology by Walter C. Kaiser, Jr. (**print**) (**Logos**)

Exegetical Tools

The ESV Study Bible (**print**) (**esv.org**)

The Open Bible (**print**) (**ebook**) (**Logos**)

Matthew Henry's Commentary on the Whole Bible (**print**) (**ccel.org**)

The NIV Application Commentary (**print**) (**Logos**)

The New International Commentary on New Testament (**print**) (**Logos**)

The New International Commentary on Old Testament (**print**) (**Logos**)

The Word Biblical Commentary (**print**) (**Logos**)

The Expositor's Bible Commentary (**print**) (**Logos**)

The Tyndale Old Testament Commentary (**print**) (**Logos**)

The Tyndale New Testament Commentary (**print**) (**Logos**)

The Holman Illustrated Bible Dictionary (**print**) (**studylight.org**)

The Anchor Yale Bible Dictionary (**Logos**) (**archive.org**)

Strong's Exhaustive Concordance of the Bible (**print**) (**biblestudytools.com**)

Young's Analytical Concordance of the Bible (**archive.org**)

Abbott-Smith's Greek Lexison of the New Testament (**Logos**) (**gutenberg.ca**)

The Brown-Driver-Briggs Hebrew-English Lexicon of the Old Testament (**biblestudytools.com**) (**ancient-hebrew.org**)

A Greek-English Lexicon of the New Testament and Other Early Christian Literature (BDAG) (**print**) (**Logos**)

A Hebrew and Aramaic Lexicon of the Old Testament (HALOT) (**print**) (**Logos**)

The Treasury of Scripture Knowledge (**tsk-online.com**) (**blueletterbible.com**)

The Thompson Chain Reference Bible (**print**) (**studylight.org**)

Glossary

Interpretation - *A judgment as to the meaning of a text.*

Hermeneutics - *The principles used to determine an interpretation of a text.*

Exegesis - *The process used to determine an interpretation of a text.*

Authorial Intent - *The original meaning intended by the author of a text.*

Verbal Plenary Inspiration - *The precise wording of Scripture is God-breathed, and therefore bears Gods authority.*

Dictation Theory of Inspiration - *God bypassed the intentions and circumstances of the human authors, "dictating" the entire content of the Bible.*

Partial/Conceptual Inspiration - *God impressed concepts into the minds of the human authors, and they wrote about them in detailed by potentially flawed ways.*

Natural Theory of Inspiration - *There is no divinity in the inspiration of the Bible. The intentions and circumstances of the human authors are all there is, and therefore, they have no real authority.*

Literal Historical Grammatic Hermeneutic - *A commonsense reading, taking into account the historical setting and linguistic choices of the author to determine his originally intended meaning.*

Moral/Allegorical Hermeneutic - *A mystical or codical reading, often attempting to identify secret patterns of words, numbers, or locations in order to unpack a more significant meaning.*

Theological Hermeneutic - *A theology-driven reading, interpreting individual passages of Scripture in the light of theological presuppositions.*

Metanarrative - *The overarching story comprised of and connecting smaller stories.*

Outlining - *The process of notating the structure, themes, and argument flow of a book of the Bible.*

Summary - *Condensing a lengthy, difficult, or complicated passage into a simple statement.*

Synthesis - *Combining multiple sources, ideas, or passages to form a single argument.*

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